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«Strategies of Legitimizing Violations of International Law in Leaders' Speeches at the United Nations General Assembly (1945–2023)»

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Abstract

How states publicly justify legally contested conduct before a universal institutional audience has received theoretical attention but limited empirical study. This thesis examines legitimation strategies employed by state leaders in UN General Assembly General Debate speeches, drawing on a criterion-based sample of 33 case-years (102 manually coded segments) Harvard UN General Debate Corpus. Directed qualitative content analysis, structured around Habermas's typology of social action, is applied alongside an eight-category manual coding framework. Counter-terrorism and securitization framing (34.3%) and procedural-legal claims (27.5%) are the dominant strategy types; strategic action is absent as a dominant mode across the sample. A significant temporal shift marks the post-2001 rise of communicative-justificatory framing, partially reversed after 2014. Cross-bloc convergence in counter-terrorism rhetoric coexists with divergence in legitimation register: Western states rely predominantly on justificatory framing while non-Western states invoke formal Charter provisions more consistently. The findings extend corpus-based evidence for deliberative legitimacy and document structurally conditioned asymmetries in how geopolitical blocs relate to the postwar normative architecture.

Keywords: legitimation strategies, UN General Assembly, communicative action, Habermas, international law, norm contestation, diplomatic discourse, geopolitical blocs

Вопрос о том, как государства публично обосновывают юридически оспариваемые действия перед универсальной институциональной аудиторией, хорошо изучен теоретически, однако систематических эмпирических исследований по-прежнему недостаточно. В работе анализируются стратегии легитимации лидеров государств в речах на Генеральной Ассамблее ООН. На основе критериальной выборки из 33 случаев (102 кодированных сегмента) Harvard UN General Debate Corpus направлен качественный контент-анализ в рамках типологии социального действия Ю. Хабермаса выявил две доминирующие стратегии: антитеррористическое и секьюритизирующее фреймирование (34,3%) и процедурно-правовые апелляции (27,5%). Стратегическое действие как доминирующий режим полностью отсутствует в выборке. Статистически значимый темпоральный сдвиг фиксирует подъём коммуникативно-юстификаторского фреймирования после 2001 года, частично обратившийся после 2014-го. Конвергенция блоков в антитеррористической риторике сочетается со структурным расхождением в регистре легитимации: западные государства опираются преимущественно на юстификаторские аргументы, тогда как советский/восточный и неприсоединившийся блоки последовательнее апеллируют к нормам Устава ООН. Результаты расширяют корпусную доказательную базу теории делиберативной легитимности и фиксируют

структурно обусловленные асимметрии в ориентации геополитических блоков относительно нормативной архитектуры послевоенного порядка.

Ключевые слова: стратегии легитимации, Генеральная Ассамблея ООН, коммуникативное действие, Хабермас, международное право, нормативное оспаривание, дипломатический дискурс, геополитические блоки

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Introduction

When a state uses military force in circumstances that other governments characterize as illegal, the diplomatic calendar offers a predictable ritual. At the United Nations General Assembly, its head of state or foreign minister takes the floor and constructs a public justification. The justification may invoke self-defense under Article 51 of the UN Charter, reframe the operation as counter-terrorism, appeal to humanitarian necessity, contest the credibility of the accusing parties, or some combination of these moves. What varies is the specific configuration and the rhetorical register. What does not vary – and this is the central empirical observation motivating this thesis – is that the move is made – publicly, on the record, in the one forum where virtually every state in the international system holds a seat – a body of 193 member governments.

This practice appears across a wide range of states, regardless of their material capabilities, political systems, or ideological positions. This raises an important question for international relations theory: why do states invest diplomatic resources in publicly justifying the use of force, even when the decision to act has already been made? States do not usually rely on military power alone. They also seek to present their actions as lawful, necessary, defensive, humanitarian, or consistent with broader principles of international order. This suggests that legitimacy matters in international politics. It is not simply a form of propaganda or a diplomatic afterthought.

The scholarly literature on legitimation in international relations has grown substantially over the past three decades. Theoretical accounts now range from Franck's (1990) early work on the compliance pull of legitimate rules, through Hurd's (1999) social constructivist account of legitimacy as belief, to Bjola's (2005) application of Habermasian communicative action theory to the justification of force, and Wiener's (2014) framework for norm contestation across institutional settings. What this body of work does not provide is a systematic, corpus-based account of which legitimation strategies actually appear in leaders' speeches at the UNGA, in what combinations, and how the repertoire has changed from the founding of the United Nations to the present. The existing empirical literature is built predominantly from case studies of individual episodes – NATO's intervention in Kosovo in 1999 (Bjola, 2005; Head, 2008), the US-led invasion of Iraq in 2003 (Rapp, 2022), the Suez crisis of 1956 (Rapp, 2022) – each of which yields analytic depth but cannot speak to aggregate patterns, frequency distributions, or longitudinal evolution. This thesis addresses that gap.

Three research questions structure the analysis. The main question asks: *What legitimation strategies are employed by state leaders in speeches delivered at the UN General Assembly General Debate to justify conduct alleged to violate international law, from 1946 to 2023?* Three sub-questions

give the investigation further structure: Which of the identified strategies occur most frequently across the sampled corpus? How has the distribution of strategies shifted across the period under study, from the Cold War decade through the post-1990 normative expansion to the fragmentation of the rules-based order after 2014? And do states from different geopolitical blocs draw on distinguishable legitimization repertoires – or does the discourse converge across bloc boundaries despite divergent strategic interests?

The study proceeds from four theory-driven hypotheses. H1 addresses rhetorical convergence: after September 2001, the adoption of counter-terrorism framing increased across all geopolitical blocs without statistically significant bloc-based differentiation – a pattern consistent with ideational convergence rather than bloc-specific rhetorical divergence. This hypothesis is falsifiable: had one bloc demonstrated systematically greater uptake of counter-terrorism language than others, or had pre-9/11 inter-bloc differences persisted into the post-2001 period, H1 would be rejected. H2 addresses the character of the legitimization repertoire: the dominant strategies deployed across the corpus – self-defense and necessity claims, counter-terrorism framings, sovereignty and non-interference appeals, and procedural-legal invocations of the UN Charter – function predominantly as normative-legal action in Habermas’s typology, oriented toward shared legal frameworks rather than toward purely strategic evasion or denial. H3 addresses temporal dynamics: the distribution of legitimization strategies shifts across historical periods, with counter-terrorism framing becoming dominant after 2001 and sovereignty-revisionist framing intensifying after 2014, rather than remaining stable across the full period of analysis. H4 addresses geopolitical variation: legitimization strategies differ systematically across Cold War blocs, with Western states showing a lower reliance on normative-legal framing relative to Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states – a divergence observable despite the surface convergence captured in H1. All four hypotheses are treated as theory-informed starting points subject to empirical testing.

The empirical basis of the analysis is the Harvard UN General Debate Corpus (UNGDC), a machine-readable dataset of all speeches delivered at the General Assembly’s annual General Debate from 1946 to 2023 – 11,127 speeches from 198 countries. The analytical sample is identified through a criterion-based procedure: state-years in which the state-sessions in which a government faced recorded accusations of conduct whose legality or normative status was disputed are selected on the basis of United Nations documentation – resolutions and meeting records of the General Assembly, Security Council proceedings, special rapporteur reports), NGO documentation (Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch), and academic secondary literature on specific conflicts and episodes. Python scripts assist in extracting and keyword-filtering the corresponding speeches from the full corpus; every identified speech

is then read and coded manually. The coding employs directed qualitative content analysis (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005) and proceeds in two stages. In the first stage, descriptive mapping establishes the frequency and co-occurrence of coded strategies across the full sample. In the second stage, comparative qualitative interpretation examines how specific strategies are realized across actors, periods, and normative contexts. The coding framework operates along two analytical dimensions: the type of alleged violation addressed, and the legitimation strategy deployed in response. Both dimensions are derived deductively from existing theory and refined through iterative engagement with the corpus material. The qualitative findings are supplemented by descriptive frequency counts and co-occurrence mapping across the full period 1946–2023.

Several limitations require stating at the outset. The corpus covers only the UNGA General Debate; positions articulated in closed Security Council sessions, bilateral correspondence, or domestic political discourse fall outside the scope of analysis. The speeches examined represent a specific genre – formal, high-stakes, public address before a global institutional audience – and the legitimation strategies identified here should not be assumed to correspond to the full range of legal or political argumentation available to states in other settings. No claim about the actual legality of the conduct in question is made anywhere in this thesis: the designation “alleged violation” in every case signals an independently documented accusation, not a legal finding. The analysis examines how states respond to that accusation in public discourse, not whether the accusation was legally correct. A further constraint concerns non-English-language speeches: while the UNGDC provides translated versions, strategic ambiguity or omissions in translation may affect the precision of coding for certain passages.

The thesis is organized as follows. Chapter 1 reviews the relevant literature across three overlapping fields: theories of legitimacy and legitimation in international relations, the UNGA General Debate as a rhetorical and institutional arena, and existing empirical research on legitimation discourse in multilateral settings. Chapter 2 develops the theoretical framework, moving from Habermas’s (1984) typology of social action and validity claims through its IR applications in Risse (2000), Müller (2004), and Bjola (2005), to an operational account of legitimation strategy for the purposes of this study. Chapter 3 describes the research design, corpus selection, sampling logic, and coding framework in detail. Chapter 4 presents the empirical findings: frequency and co-occurrence patterns, comparative case analysis across three dominant strategy types, and a longitudinal account of how the repertoire has shifted across the period 1946–2023. Chapter 5 interprets these findings against the theoretical framework, assesses all four hypotheses, and identifies the study’s contributions and limitations. The conclusion returns directly to the main research question and states what the analysis has established.

1. Literature Review

1.1. Legitimacy in International Relations: Theoretical Landscape

Legitimacy has become an increasingly important, if contested, concept in IR scholarship on the postwar international order. Its theoretical status shifted substantially over the past three decades, moving from a largely normative concern – whether particular norms or institutions *deserved* compliance – toward a more empirical and relational question of how legitimacy functions as a social fact structuring state behavior.

Thomas Franck's (1990) foundational contribution established the link between legitimacy and rule compliance within the international legal system. Franck's central question – why states comply with international legal rules in the absence of centralized coercive enforcement – led him to the concept of *compliance pull*: the force that legitimate rules exert on state behavior independently of coercive sanctions. He identified four properties that assess how strongly a given rule commands compliance: whether its formulation is clear and precise enough to guide behavior, whether recognized procedural markers confer authenticity upon it, whether it sits consistently within the surrounding body of legal principle, and whether it occupies a defined position within an established normative hierarchy. The framework treated legitimacy as an observable quality of rules rather than a purely philosophical attribute, and positioned it as a matter of degree rather than a binary judgment. This insight provides a starting point for analysing why states seek to attach contested conduct to legal norms that retain recognized legitimacy.

Hurd (1999) offered an equally important reorientation. Departing from coercion- and interest-based accounts of norm compliance, Hurd argued that legitimacy operates as a third mechanism of social control – alongside coercion and self-interest – grounded in internalized belief in the rightness of norms. As Hurd defines it, legitimacy is “the normative belief by an actor that a rule or institution ought to be obeyed” – a subjective, relational quality constituted by the actor's perception of the norm rather than by the norm's objective properties (Hurd, 1999, p. 381). The critical move was to treat legitimacy as a social fact rather than an evaluative standard: what matters analytically is not whether a norm meets an external criterion of justice but whether relevant actors believe it to be binding. This constructivist reframing opened legitimacy to empirical analysis: if it is constituted through belief and practice, it can be traced in the public statements and justificatory moves of state actors – precisely the objects this study examines.

Gronau and Schmidtke (2016) positioned legitimation as an active, top-down practice rather than a passive outcome of norm compliance. Building on Weberian ideas about legitimacy and domination, they developed a typology of legitimation strategies organized around three distinct constituencies: member

states, institutional staff, and wider publics. While their empirical focus was on international institutions – the G8 and the IMF during periods of contested authority – their conceptual architecture can be adapted to state actors addressing multilateral audiences.

Wiener's (2014) norm contestation framework provides a further theoretical resource. Where earlier constructivist accounts treated legitimacy as a relatively stable attribute of particular rules reproduced within established communities of practice, Wiener argues that contestation is itself a norm-generative social practice: through acts of challenging, questioning, and justifying, actors continuously re-enact the normative structure of meaning-in-use, which is the basis of legitimacy in global governance (Wiener, 2014). Legitimation, in this view, is not a one-off act of compliance or defection but a running negotiation over what a norm means and who it binds. This has direct implications for the temporal scope of the present study: the evolution of legitimation strategies from 1946 to 2023 reflects an ongoing contestation over the terms of the postwar normative architecture, not a fixed repertoire deployed against a fixed standard.

1.2. Diplomacy as Public Communication: the UNGA as a Rhetorical Arena

The United Nations General Assembly General Debate is one of the most regularized and visible genres of public diplomatic communication in the international system. Convened annually each September, it provides every member state with a designated speaking slot before the full plenary – an opportunity that governments consistently use to state positions on contested norms, respond to international criticism, and present their preferred interpretation of international events before a universal audience. The ritual character of the event – fixed institutional setting, established speaking order, universal participation, near-identical format from year to year – makes it unusually tractable for systematic analysis. Genre constraints are relatively uniform across decades and states, which reduces the interpretive noise that arises when comparing speech events from radically different institutional contexts.

The Harvard UN General Debate Corpus (UNGDC), introduced by Baturo, Dasandi, and Mikhaylov (2017), made systematic text-as-data analysis of the General Debate feasible for the first time. The original dataset comprises 7,314 statements from 198 countries covering sessions 1970–2014; the corpus has since been extended on Harvard Dataverse to cover sessions from 1946 to 2023, comprising 11,127 speeches in its current release. Baturo et al. (2017) demonstrate that GD speeches can serve as empirical proxies for state preferences precisely because they are less constrained than UNGA roll-call votes: unlike voting, where aid relationships and strategic blocs shape behaviour, states deliver their addresses without direct institutional stakes, which means the choice of topics and emphases more freely reflects national priorities. Representatives of the Finnish and German missions to the UN, interviewed by

the authors, described GD speeches as the place where states “speak their mind” and “the most sovereign thing that a country does as a member of the UN” (Baturu et al., 2017, p. 2). Preference scores derived from the corpus have been cross-validated against independent foreign policy indicators, establishing their construct validity across multiple measurement approaches. Research drawing on this dataset has concentrated primarily on recovering ideological alignment and positional signals; the analytical framework here treats the same textual material with a qualitatively oriented analytical framework applied to a theoretically motivated sub-sample. A relevant limitation is that GD speeches are strategically constructed performances: as Baturu et al. (2017, p. 3) note, “member states present themselves exclusively in the guise in which they wish to be known.” For the purposes of the present analysis, however, this is a feature rather than a flaw – the strategic construction of public justification is precisely the object of inquiry.

The General Debate occupies an ambiguous position between communicative and strategic action – a distinction central to the theoretical framework developed in Chapter 2. On one account, it functions as a site of public deliberation: governments advance positions, respond to challenges, and expose their reasoning to scrutiny before a universal and formally equal audience. On another, it operates as a performance arena where states manage reputational risks, address domestic audiences through international ones, and deploy available normative vocabulary without genuine openness to argumentative revision. Neither account fully captures the phenomenon. What can be said is that the General Debate is the most consistently attended, most formally institutionalized, and most universally accessible arena where heads of state and foreign ministers place their governments' legal and normative positions on the record before a universal audience — a feature that makes it the analytically appropriate venue for studying legitimization strategies across the full membership of the United Nations rather than one episode at a time.

1.3. Existing Research on Legitimation Discourse in UN Speeches: Contributions and Gaps

The scholarly literature on the legitimization of contested conduct in multilateral settings has generated a body of analytically rich case studies that establish the importance of the phenomenon while leaving systematic questions unanswered.

Bjola (2005) provides the most theoretically developed account within this tradition. Applying Habermas's theory of communicative action to the NATO military campaign in Kosovo (1999) and the coalition-led military action in Iraq (2003), Bjola contends that the degree of legitimacy accorded to military action cannot be settled by reference to UN Charter compliance alone. His concept of *deliberative legitimacy*, defined as “the non-coerced commitment of an actor to obey a norm adopted on the basis of

the criteria and rules reached through a process of communicative action” (Bjola, 2005, p. 266), introduces a procedural standard that distinguishes genuine normative justification from strategic persuasion. The diagnostic question is whether the promoters of intervention genuinely sought “a reasoned consensus on the need for the use of force” or merely engaged in “power games based on credible threats, intimidation or rhetorical exchanges with no visible intention to achieve argumentative consensus” (Bjola, 2005, p. 267). Assessed against this standard, the two cases yield contrasting findings. In the Kosovo episode, alliance members modified their positions in response to arguments and the process, however imperfect, remained genuinely open to deliberative revision. The Iraq episode was dominated by strategic action: the United States manipulated the legal framing of Resolution 1441 without openness to argumentative revision, seeking agreement rather than understanding. The analytical value of this distinction is considerable; its empirical scope is not. Two cases, both Western-led, selected for their visibility rather than their representativeness, cannot speak to whether similar patterns obtain across the full range of legitimization contexts the postwar system has generated.

Head (2008) extends the Habermasian approach into a more explicitly critical register, demonstrating that patterns of “exclusion, coercion and illegitimacy... not only challenge the claims to legitimacy of the intervention and of the interveners, but demonstrate the critical power of a communicative framework” (Head, 2008, p. 150). The Kosovo episode supplies the evidence: Kosovar Albanians were structurally absent from Security Council deliberations – having no state and therefore no seat – which meant the principal affected party had no standing in a process nominally conducted on its behalf. The Rambouillet negotiations reproduced the same asymmetry, with the Contact Group setting terms while the threat of air strikes functioned as an instrument of pressure rather than persuasion. Head’s concern is normative, but the analytical observation generalizes: case-study methods can identify such structural dynamics with precision, but cannot measure their prevalence, frequency, or variation across the diversity of the UN membership and the full postwar period.

Rapp (2022) approaches the problem through an entirely different method. Drawing on declassified archival documents from British and American decision-makers, he traces the internal reasoning behind legal justifications for force in the Suez crisis (1956) and the Grenada military intervention (1983). His central claim is that “in a deeply legalized system actors feel compelled to portray their behaviors as legal, even if these justifications are tenuous or if pursuing them is time and resource consuming” (Rapp, 2022, p. 337). The justificatory preference followed a clear hierarchy: references to codified treaty obligations were preferred over customary international law, and both were preferred over non-legal rationales, because written legal text offers a standard that opponents find harder to dismiss. In

the Suez case, British officials sought not the legally strongest argument but the most *palatably* legal one – the formulation most capable of managing anticipated criticism. In the Grenada case, the United States assembled three individually weak grounds into a composite justification – an invitation from the Governor-General, a threat to American citizens, and authorization under the OECS regional treaty – because no single argument was persuasive in isolation. The contribution is significant, establishing that legitimation is a strategic and resource-intensive practice even for preponderant states. The method, however, forecloses analysis of the public dimension: the speeches delivered to the UN General Assembly in these same episodes remain unexamined, and the gap between internal decision-making and public justification is itself an analytically interesting object.

Taken together, this body of work establishes several important premises: that the legitimation of legally contested conduct is a systematic practice across a wide range of states and contexts; that the UN General Assembly and the Security Council are the primary arenas for its public expression; and that the gap between formal legal compliance and perceived legitimacy is analytically tractable. What the existing literature does not provide is a systematic account of which legitimation strategies appear in the UNGDC corpus, in what combinations, with what frequency, and how the distribution has shifted across the postwar period. The published research consists of deep vertical borings into particular episodes; the horizontal view – across states, across time, across violation types – remains unavailable. This study addresses that gap.

2. Theoretical Framework

2.1. Habermas's Theory of Communicative Action: Core Tenets and Typology

The theoretical foundation of this study rests on Jürgen Habermas's theory of communicative action, developed in *The Theory of Communicative Action*, first published in German in 1981. Habermas's project was animated by dissatisfaction with accounts of rationality that reduced it to instrumental and strategic reason, oriented toward the efficient pursuit of pre-given ends. Against this, he argued that a second form of rationality – *communicative rationality* – is embedded in the structures of language use and oriented not toward success but toward mutual understanding (*Verständigung*). This shift from a subject-object to a subject-subject paradigm is the conceptual foundation on which his typology of social action rests.

In Volume 1, Chapter I, Habermas distinguishes four concepts of social action. *Teleological action* – and, when it incorporates other actors as part of the strategic calculus, *strategic action* – is oriented toward the attainment of an end through the selection of appropriate means. *Normatively regulated action* refers to behavior governed by shared group values; in later institutionalist terms, it approximates the logic of appropriateness. *Dramaturgical action* involves the self-presentation of an actor before an audience, the management of impressions in a social performance. *Communicative action* is the fourth and analytically central type: action coordinated through language oriented toward reaching intersubjective agreement, in which actors seek to harmonize their plans not through incentives, threats, or norm compliance alone, but by advancing claims that are open to reasoned acceptance or rejection. As Habermas puts it, “the communicative model of action does not equate action with communication. Language is a means of communication which serves mutual understanding, whereas actors, in coming to an understanding with one another so as to coordinate their actions, pursue their particular aims” (Habermas, 1984, p. 101).

Following the IR applications of Habermas developed by Risse and Bjola, this study focuses on three validity claims most relevant to political justification. *Truth* concerns whether the propositional content corresponds to states of affairs in the objective world. *Rightness* concerns whether the utterance is normatively appropriate within a shared social world and whether the underlying norm can be justified. *Sincerity* concerns whether the expression corresponds to the speaker's actual intentions. These claims carry the expectation that they could, in principle, be defended discursively if challenged. The communicative model treats speech not as the mere transmission of information but as a form of social action in which coordination depends on the intersubjective recognition of validity.

The distinction between communicative and strategic action is the analytical axis most relevant to this study. Strategic action is oriented toward success (*Erfolg*) – the achievement of the actor's own

objectives regardless of others' genuine agreement; communicative action is oriented toward understanding (*Verständigung*) – a shared assessment of a situation arrived at through reasons that all parties can in principle accept. Habermas identifies a degenerate but empirically pervasive phenomenon he terms *systematically distorted communication*: strategic action dressed in the grammar of communicative exchange, deploying the surface forms of reasoned argument while remaining, at the level of orientation, purely strategic. This tension is especially relevant for UNGA speeches, where heads of government may justify legally contested conduct before a universal audience in the language of reasoned argument, even when the purpose is reputational management rather than genuine argumentative revision.

2.2. Communicative Action in International Relations

The application of Habermas's theory to world politics required a deliberate theoretical translation. Much of mainstream IR theory, particularly rationalist and realist work, had long been organized around interest-based models – rational choice bargaining, deterrence theory, the strategic logic of great-power competition – that treated communication as epiphenomenal to power and interest. The constructivist turn of the 1990s brought normative factors back into analytical view, but the specific question of argumentation as a mode of social action required a further step.

Thomas Risse (2000) made that step in a widely cited contribution. Against the bilateral opposition between consequentialist rationalism and constructivist appropriateness, Risse proposed a third mode of social interaction: the logic of arguing. "Processes of argumentation, deliberation, and persuasion," he contended, "constitute a distinct mode of social interaction to be differentiated from both strategic bargaining...and rule-guided behavior" (Risse, 2000, p. 1). Actors engaged in arguing advance truth claims or normative validity claims with a genuine openness to revising their positions in light of better arguments – which is what distinguishes arguing from bargaining (adjusting positions through promises and threats) and from rhetorical action (deploying the forms of argument without readiness for revision) (Risse, 2000). Risse distinguishes between two settings in which argumentative processes operate in international relations: restricted diplomatic exchanges among small numbers of participants, where actors may undergo genuine shifts in their stated preferences, is at least conceivable; and open, public discourses addressed to wider audiences where argumentative accountability operates at a different scale. The UNGA General Debate belongs to the second category – its institutionalized, universally public character makes it a site where states must advance normative justifications subject, in principle, to scrutiny from all 193 member states. Whether that scrutiny produces genuine arguing or merely a strategic performance of argument is precisely the empirical question this study examines.

Harald Müller (2004) introduced an important conceptual refinement to Risse's framework. Risse had treated "arguing" and "communicative action" as roughly synonymous – both contrasted with bargaining and strategic action. Müller showed that this collapsed a critical distinction: "arguing and bargaining are simply two different types of speech acts... Communicative and strategic action, in contrast, are not speech acts, but types of action that include the wider orientation of the speakers" (Müller, 2004, p. 396). The consequence is that strategic actors can and do use arguing speech acts, deploying the form of reasoned justification instrumentally without any genuine openness to argumentative revision. As Müller observes, "Jon Elster (1991) has shown how strategic actors would use arguing for winning over their partners to their own preferences if they believe that arguments are a better way to win than promises and threats" (Müller, 2004, p. 397). For this study, the distinction is analytically essential: the presence of arguing speech acts in UNGA addresses does not establish that the speaker is engaged in communicative action. The coding framework, developed in Section 2.3 below, therefore tracks strategies – types of speech act – separately from the question of orientation, which is addressed in the interpretive analysis of Chapter 4.

Corneliu Bjola (2005) offered the most direct bridge between the Habermasian framework and the analysis of legitimation in diplomatic practice. Bjola argued that legal compliance criteria – specifically, UNSC authorization – are insufficient to distinguish legitimate from illegitimate uses of force, because legal standards can themselves become objects of strategic manipulation. He proposed instead the concept of deliberative legitimacy, defined as "the non-coerced commitment of an actor to obey a norm adopted on the basis of the criteria and rules reached through a process of communicative action" (Bjola, 2005, p. 266). The operative question is whether a discourse is genuinely oriented toward building a reasoned consensus or whether it performs the grammar of argument while remaining structurally closed to outcome: "Do the promoters of military interventions try to reach a reasoned consensus on the need for the use of force, or do they just engage in power games based on credible threats, intimidation or rhetorical exchanges with no visible intention to achieve argumentative consensus?" (Bjola, 2005, p. 267). Applying this distinction to the Kosovo and Iraq cases, Bjola found that NATO's deliberative process prior to 1999 exhibited at least some features of communicative action – positions shifted in response to arguments advanced within the alliance – while the Bush administration's management of the Security Council process in 2002–2003 was characterized by strategic action: legal language (Resolution 1441) used to construct cover for a decision that was not open to argumentative revision (Bjola, 2005).

Naomi Head (2008) extended this analysis toward the procedural conditions under which legitimating discourse can be considered genuinely communicative. Drawing on Habermas's concept of

the ideal speech situation – defined by equal standing to initiate and participate in discourse, the right to challenge claims, and the absence of coercion – Head identified patterns of structural exclusion that distort apparently deliberative processes even when they occur in formally multilateral settings. “Habermas develops the ideal speech situation in order to be able to distinguish genuine communication from false or pseudo-communication,” she observes (Head, 2008, p. 152). In the Kosovo case, the exclusion of Kosovo Albanians from Security Council deliberations and the coercive framing of the Rambouillet negotiations meant that even the procedural forms of dialogue failed to satisfy minimal conditions of non-distorted communication (Head, 2008). For this study, Head’s analysis points toward a structural feature of UNGA speeches that bears on their interpretation: states delivering legitimization addresses before the General Assembly are not participants in an equal deliberative exchange – they occupy a structurally marked position within an asymmetric communicative space, defending conduct that is already the subject of public contestation.

The synthesis these four contributions enable can be stated as follows. State leaders addressing the UNGA in the wake of legally contested actions face a situation in which the validity claim of *rightness* – the normative appropriateness of their conduct – is under explicit challenge. They must respond publicly, before a universal audience, and in a genre that carries the institutional expectation of normative justification. The theoretical expectation – grounded in Habermas’s typology, Risse’s distinction between arguing and rhetorical action, Müller’s speech-act correction, and Bjola’s deliberative legitimacy framework – is that the dominant mode will be strategic action in communicative form: arguing speech acts deployed without genuine openness to argumentative revision. Verifying that expectation, and mapping the specific strategies through which it is realized, is the task of Chapters 3 and 4.

2.3. Operationalizing Legitimation in Diplomatic Discourse

Converting the theoretical framework into an analytical instrument requires specifying what is to be observed in UNGA speech texts. Legitimation, as used in this study, refers to the public construction of normative justifications for conduct whose legality or normative acceptability is publicly disputed. This definition draws on Gronau and Schmidtke’s (2016) characterization of legitimation as a goal-oriented practice and connects it to the Habermasian account of validity claims – specifically the claim of *rightness* – as the dimension of speech at stake when states seek to defend contested actions before international audiences.

The coding framework operationalizes legitimation along two analytical dimensions. The first captures the *type of alleged violation* that the speech is responding to: (1) use of force and *jus ad bellum* allegations (contested resort to armed force); (2) IHL allegations (conduct alleged to violate the laws of

armed conflict); (3) human rights allegations (domestic repression, mass atrocities, persecution); (4) territorial integrity and sovereignty claims (annexation, occupation, contested secession); (5) treaty and UNSC-resolution non-compliance. These categories are not mutually exclusive – a single address may respond to overlapping allegations – but they provide the primary contextual variable against which the choice of legitimization strategy can be assessed.

The second dimension captures the *legitimation strategy* itself: the discursive move through which the speaker constructs normative cover for the contested action. Eight strategy types are distinguished: (1) *self-defense and necessity claims* – a cluster of defensive justifications encompassing both the legal right of self-defense under Art. 51 of the UN Charter and broader appeals to necessity (security, political, or humanitarian) that frame the action as unavoidable given the circumstances; (2) *sovereignty and non-interference* – characterization of external critique as illegitimate intervention in domestic affairs; (3) *denial and reinterpretation* – factual denial of the alleged conduct or its redescription under a non-violating frame; (4) *moral and humanitarian framing* – positioning the action as morally obligatory or as the lesser harm, including humanitarian justifications that invoke the protection of civilians or endangered populations; (5) *counter-terrorism and securitization framing* – invocation of exceptional threat, terrorist designation, or civilizational danger to justify departure from ordinary legal standards; (6) *whataboutism and tu quoque* – deflection through accusation of the accuser or generalization of the alleged violation as universal; (7) *procedural-legal claims* – appeals to formal procedural compliance, treaty authority, or multilateral authorization; (8) *historical and existential narratives* – justification grounded in historical grievance, territorial-historical claims, or identity-based existential framing.

The cross-tabulation of these two dimensions – violation type against strategy type – generates the analytical matrix for the empirical chapter. Descriptive frequencies identify which strategies are most common within the selected sample and which cluster around particular violation types, providing a basis for assessing the two hypotheses stated in Section 2.4. The qualitative comparative analysis in Chapter 4 then examines how the same strategies manifest differently across actors, periods, and normative contexts, and what that variation reveals about the communicative structure of legitimization at the UNGA.

2.4. Research Hypotheses

On the basis of the theoretical framework developed in Sections 2.1–2.3 and the literature reviewed in Chapter 1, four hypotheses are advanced for empirical testing in Chapter 4.

H1 (ideational convergence). Post-9/11 counter-terrorism framing increases uniformly across all geopolitical blocs with no statistically significant inter-bloc differentiation – a pattern consistent with ideational convergence rather than divergence. The theoretical basis is twofold. First, UNSC Resolution

1373 (2001) formally established counter-terrorism as a universal obligation, making securitization framing available to all state actors regardless of their underlying normative position. Second, Wiener's (2014) theory of contestation predicts that a norm-generative event of sufficient salience – here, the institutionalization of the counter-terrorism framework – can reset the available repertoire of legitimation resources across the international system, displacing prior bloc-specific patterns. This hypothesis is falsifiable: it would be rejected if one bloc showed systematically greater uptake of counter-terrorism language than others in the post-2001 period.

H2 (repertoire). The dominant legitimation strategies across the corpus will function as normative-legal action in Habermas's (1984) typology – oriented toward shared legal frameworks and validity claims of *rightness* – rather than as purely strategic evasion or denial. The theoretical derivation runs as follows. Bjola (2005) and Müller (2004) establish that states in institutionalized multilateral settings deploy arguing speech acts even when their underlying orientation is strategic; the forum structure generates a normative performance requirement. In the UNGA's institutional setting – public, universal, founded on the Charter architecture – states face strong incentives to construct justifications grounded in shared legal standards, because purely strategic speech acts (denial, counter-accusation, delegitimation) forfeit the legitimating function that public justification is meant to serve. The hypothesis is falsifiable: it would be rejected if strategic action – as defined by the Habermas typology – constituted the dominant mode across the sample.

H3 (temporal shift). The distribution of legitimation strategies shifts significantly across historical periods, rather than remaining stable across the 77-year period of analysis. Specifically: normative-legal framing is predicted to dominate during the Cold War; communicative justification – particularly counter-terrorism framing – to surge in the post-9/11 period; and sovereignty-revisionist normative framing to intensify after 2014, consistent with the fragmentation of the post-Cold War normative consensus documented in recent IR scholarship. The theoretical basis is Wiener's (2014) norm contestation framework: if norms are continuously contested and their meaning is reproduced through practice, then major ruptures in the normative environment – the end of the Cold War, the post-9/11 security turn, the post-2014 fragmentation – should produce observable shifts in the repertoire of legitimation resources that states can plausibly deploy. The hypothesis is falsifiable: it would be rejected if the chi-square test across periods yielded a non-significant result.

H4 (geopolitical differentiation). Legitimation strategies differ systematically across Cold War blocs, with Western states showing a lower reliance on normative-legal framing relative to Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states – a divergence observable despite the surface convergence captured in H1. The

theoretical derivation follows from the structural account in Section 2.3: if legitimation strategies are shaped by the normative standards that a speaker's core audience accepts as legitimate grounds, then bloc membership – as a proxy for shared normative context – should predict rhetorical patterns. Western states operating outside the Security Council authorization framework face a structural disincentive against formal Charter invocations; Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states, whose contested conduct typically concerns the exercise of domestic sovereign authority, have stronger incentives to invoke Charter provisions on sovereignty and non-interference. This structural asymmetry – not strategic preference – is predicted to generate the observable register divergence. The hypothesis is falsifiable: it would be rejected if the chi-square and Fisher's exact tests across blocs yielded non-significant results.

All four hypotheses are tested in Chapter 4 against the 33-case sample. Their results are interpreted in Chapter 5.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research Design: A Two-Level Analytical Strategy

The analytical approach adopted in this study combines two complementary levels of analysis, each designed to answer a distinct set of research questions and together enabling both breadth and interpretive depth that neither level could achieve alone.

The **first level** is a corpus-level keyword signal analysis, applied to a broad sample of speeches drawn from the full Harvard UN General Debate Corpus (UNGDC). This level is designed to address the macro-questions motivating the study: When does the frequency of particular legitimization-related linguistic signals increase or decrease across time? Are these changes associated with geopolitical bloc membership, historical period, or the profile of actors involved in the discourse? The corpus-level analysis does not code individual arguments; it tracks the normalized keyword density of seven thematic signals – counter-terrorism and securitization framing, self-defense appeals, sovereignty invocations, humanitarian discourse, procedural-legal references, historical framing, and whataboutism – across over 11,000 speeches, disaggregated by Cold War bloc membership and nine sub-periods: 1946–1959, 1960–1969, 1970–1979, 1980–1989, 1990–2001, 2002–2008, 2009–2013, 2014–2019, and 2020–2023. These nine sub-periods serve exclusively as the temporal grid for corpus-level signal trend analysis and are distinct from the four conceptually defined historical periods used for case-level coding in Section 3.4.3. Where the nine sub-periods are approximately decadal intervals chosen to ensure adequate speech volume per cell, the four analytical periods in Section 3.4.3 are defined by geopolitical inflection points (the end of the Cold War, the post-9/11 security turn, and the post-2014 normative fragmentation) and serve as the interpretive frame for the case-level comparative analysis. This level is the primary evidentiary basis for testing H1 (convergence) and provides contextual grounding for the temporal patterns examined in H3.

The second level is a directed qualitative content analysis of 33 case-years identified through the criterion-based sampling procedure described in Section 3.3. This level engages the 102 coded argumentative segments from those cases and classifies each according to Habermas's (1984) four-type taxonomy of social action. This level is the primary evidentiary basis for testing H2, H3, and H4, and generates the comparative case analysis in Chapter 4.

The rationale for this two-level design is directly tied to the gap identified in Chapter 1. Existing research consists predominantly of case studies that yield analytic depth but cannot speak to patterns across actors, periods, and violation types (Bjola, 2005; Rapp, 2022). What the literature lacks is a horizontal account: which strategies are deployed, with what frequency, in what combinations, and how the distribution has shifted over time. The corpus-level analysis provides the horizontal account at scale;

the case-level analysis provides the interpretive depth necessary to understand the rhetorical logic of individual legitimation moves. The two levels are designed to be mutually illuminating rather than redundant.

Within the second level, the analytical procedure unfolds in two stages. The first stage is *descriptive mapping*: classifying all segments in the sample against the Habermas typology, calculating frequencies and co-occurrence patterns, and generating the quantitative findings reported in Sections 4.3–4.6. The second stage is *comparative qualitative interpretation*: examining in closer detail how specific legitimation strategies are realized in representative cases – which rhetorical resources are deployed, which legal and normative frameworks are invoked, and how the framing responds to the specific allegation addressed. As Hsieh and Shannon (2005) argue in their account of directed content analysis, this combination of deductive category-driven coding with qualitative interpretation allows a study to move between the pattern level and the meaning level in a principled way.

The unit of analysis is the argumentative segment – a sentence or sequence of sentences constituting a rhetorically complete justificatory move. A single speech may contain multiple coded segments, each classified independently, since states defending contested conduct typically assemble composite justifications rather than relying on a single argument.

3.2. Data: The Harvard UN General Debate Corpus

The primary data source is the UN General Debate Corpus (UNGDC). The original corpus was compiled from UN official records and published on Harvard Dataverse by Baturo, Dasandi, and Mikhaylov (2017), who made available the full texts of speeches delivered during the General Debate of the United Nations General Assembly for sessions spanning 1970 to 2014, as a structured text-as-data resource. The extended version used in this study was developed by Jankin, Baturo, and Dasandi (2025), who expanded coverage backward to the inaugural General Assembly session in 1946 and forward through 2023. As employed in the present study, the corpus encompasses 11,127 speeches from 198 countries across nearly eight decades of General Debate sessions.

The corpus offers several properties that make it suitable for both levels of the analysis. Speeches are available as plain-text files, machine-readable and standardized in format, with consistent metadata on the year of delivery, country, and session number. The General Debate format is highly uniform across time: each member state receives a designated speaking slot, delivers an address on topics of its choosing before a plenary audience that includes the full UN membership. As Baturo et al. (2017, p. 3) observe, this genre stability – combined with the fact that “member states present themselves exclusively in the guise in which they wish to be known” – makes the corpus particularly well-suited to the systematic analysis of

strategic legitimization discourse. Rather than treating strategic self-presentation as a distortion to be corrected, this study takes it as its primary analytical object.

The corpus-level analysis draws on the full UNGDC for signal frequency computation. The case-level analysis draws on 33 state-years identified through the criterion-based procedure described below. Python scripts serve three preparatory functions: extracting speeches for identified state-years; applying the keyword-based role classifier to all segments; and generating the corpus-level keyword signal scores used for ANOVA and temporal trend analysis.

Two limitations of the corpus require acknowledgment. First, speeches originally delivered in languages other than English are represented through official UN translations. The translation process introduces the possibility that strategic nuances in the original are smoothed out or lost, which the qualitative interpretive stage notes where salient. Second, speeches prior to approximately 1992 were stored as scanned copies of printed records and required OCR processing, which may affect text quality for some early sessions (Baturo et al., 2017; Jankin et al., 2025).

3.3. Case Identification and Geopolitical Classification

3.3.1. Criterion-Based Case Selection

The analytical sample for the case-level analysis includes all speeches in the UNGDC that satisfy the study's inclusion criterion: the delivering state faced documented external criticism or allegation of legally or normatively contested conduct at the time of the relevant UNGA session, and the speech itself contains material – direct or indirect – addressing that contested conduct. No predetermined N constrains the sample; the inclusion criterion is applied systematically to the full corpus. The present study identifies 33 state-years meeting both conditions, spanning 18 states across all four analytical periods (Cold War: 8 cases; post-Cold War normative expansion: 9; post-9/11 security turn: 8; post-2014 normative fragmentation: 8).

Case identification proceeds in two steps. First, episodes of legally or normatively contested conduct are identified using contextual documentation: UN reporting (General Assembly and Security Council records, special rapporteur reports), NGO documentation (Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch annual reports), and academic secondary literature on specific conflicts. These sources document that a state faced external criticism at the time of its UNGA address; they do not establish that a legal violation occurred, and no claim about the legality of the conduct is made. Second, identified state-years are checked against the UNGDC to confirm that the speech for that country and session is available and contains material relevant to the contested episode. Speeches that make no reference – direct or indirect – to the contested conduct are excluded.

3.3.2. Cold War Bloc Classification

The geopolitical comparative dimension of the analysis is structured around three Cold War institutional blocs: the Western bloc (NATO member states and their formal allies), the Soviet/Eastern bloc (Warsaw Pact member states and Soviet-aligned governments), and the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM member states and formally uncommitted governments). The choice of this classification over alternative schemes – UN regional groups, regime type classifications, or contemporary alliance configurations – requires explicit justification.

The Cold War bloc classification is most appropriate for the temporal scope of this study for three interconnected reasons. First, the study covers 77 years of UN General Assembly discourse (1946–2023), the majority of which – roughly 44 years (1946–1989) – falls within the predominantly bipolar international system shaped by the Cold War. During this period, bloc membership was not merely a diplomatic affiliation but a marker of shared normative contexts, overlapping legal frameworks, and distinctive vocabularies of legitimate international conduct. Western bloc states operated within a liberal internationalist normative framework emphasizing rule-based order and human rights conditionality; Soviet/Eastern bloc states prioritized formal sovereignty and non-interference as counterweights to Western interventionism; Non-Aligned states, shaped by the Bandung tradition, decolonization, and South–South diplomatic coordination, constructed a third normative repertoire emphasizing anti-colonialism, sovereign equality, non-interference, and self-determination (Prashad, 2007; Dinkel, 2019). If legitimization strategies are shaped by the normative standards that a speaker’s core audience accepts as legitimate grounds – which the Habermasian framework would predict – then bloc membership is the analytically relevant dimension.

Second, the bloc structure remains institutionally stable across the full period, unlike post-Cold War alliance configurations or economic groupings which have shifted substantially. The core composition of the Western and Soviet/Eastern blocs remained stable from the early 1950s through 1991. The Non-Aligned Movement, while more heterogeneous, maintained a broadly consistent normative orientation from its founding. This stability allows meaningful temporal comparison across all four analytical periods without requiring recoding of states’ positions.

Third, the only structural disruption – the entry of fourteen Eastern European states into NATO after 1991 – is handled through a period-aware transition rule (BLOC_TRANSITIONS): states retain their Soviet/Eastern bloc classification through their year of NATO accession, after which they are reclassified as Western bloc. The states affected by this rule (including Bulgaria, Czech Republic, Estonia, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, Slovenia – 2004; Albania, Croatia – 2009; Montenegro –

2017; North Macedonia – 2020) do not appear in the 33-case sample, so the transition rule does not affect the reported results. Its inclusion preserves conceptual integrity and relevance for any expanded analysis.

Whether blocs can be shown to differ in their legitimation repertoires is precisely what the statistical comparisons in Chapter 4 test. The bloc classification is not assumed to produce differences; it is a theoretically motivated hypothesis that the data either support or reject.

3.4. Coding Framework

3.4.1. Habermas's Typology as the Master Coding Architecture

The case-level analysis classifies each coded segment according to Habermas's (1984) four-type taxonomy of social action. The decision to apply this deductively derived framework rather than developing categories inductively from the corpus follows the logic of directed qualitative content analysis: when existing theory provides sufficiently specified categories, it is both methodologically more defensible and analytically more productive to test those categories against new data rather than reinventing a descriptive vocabulary (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005). Prior IR scholarship supports the applicability of Habermas's typology to multilateral diplomatic discourse. Risse (2000) demonstrates that the distinction between arguing and bargaining – which maps directly onto communicative versus strategic action in Habermas's framework – generates empirically testable predictions about actor behavior in international institutions. Müller (2004) extends this by showing that the distinction operates at the level of actor *orientation* (toward understanding vs. toward success) rather than at the level of specific speech acts, which means that the same argumentative form can be communicative or strategic depending on the speaker's underlying orientation toward the audience. Bjola (2005) applies the framework directly to UNGA-adjacent discourse, demonstrating its purchase on the analysis of how states construct deliberative legitimacy for contested uses of force.

The nine communicative roles employed in this study are derived deductively from the four Habermas types and operationalized as shown in Table 3.1.

Table 3.1

Habermas's Typology and Communicative Roles

Habermas type	Validity claim	Communicative roles covered
Communicative action (<i>Verständigung</i>)	Truth	Justification; dialogue appeal

Habermas type	Validity claim	Communicative roles covered
Normative action (<i>Richtigkeit</i>)	Rightness	Legal-normative invocation; sovereignty norm
Dramaturgical action (<i>Wahrhaftigkeit</i>)	Sincerity	Historical context; victim narrative
Strategic action (success-oriented)	–	Denial; counter-accusation; delegitimation

This four-part structure allows the analysis to ask not only *which* strategies appear, but *what kind of legitimation work* they perform: whether states construct shared reasons (communicative), invoke shared norms (normative), stage authentic self-presentation (dramaturgical), or attempt to foreclose the legitimation game entirely (strategic). As Rapp (2022) observes, in a deeply legalized international system, actors face strong pressure to construct legal justifications even when those justifications are tenuous – which implies that the mode of legitimation itself carries information about the normative constraints states perceive themselves to be operating under.

3.4.2. Keyword-Based Classification Procedure

Each identified argumentative segment is classified using a keyword density scoring procedure applied across nine role-specific lexicons. For each segment, the score for role *r* is computed as:

$$\text{score}(r) = (\text{keyword matches for role } r / \text{total words in segment}) \times 1,000.$$

This yields a hits-per-thousand-words metric that normalizes for segment length. The dominant role assigned to a segment is the role with the highest non-zero score across all nine lexicons. Segments that return a score of zero across all nine lexicons are designated *unclassified*; these are analyzed separately as a methodologically informative category rather than treated as missing data.

This procedure is not a substitute for the manual reading and interpretation of each speech. Rather, it operationalizes the theoretical categories in a reproducible, transparent, and consistently applied way across the full 33-case sample. Each lexicon was developed deductively from the theoretical definitions in Chapter 2, then refined through iterative engagement with a pilot subset of speeches to ensure that

keyword patterns reliably track the corresponding argumentative moves. The full lexicons are documented in the study's analytical code (scripts/ml/communicative_roles.py).

The overall unclassified rate is 4.9 percent (5 of 102 segments). The slightly elevated rate for the Western bloc subcorpus (three segments) is itself analytically relevant: it reflects the more institutionally indirect and hedged argumentative style characteristic of US and Israeli diplomatic discourse in the sample periods, where justificatory arguments are often constructed through elaborate conditional framings rather than explicit keyword-dense assertions. This pattern matches Rapp's (2022) observation that actors in highly legalized contexts invest significant resources in constructing *legally palatable* arguments rather than simply asserting positions directly.

In addition to the Habermas-type classification derived from keyword scoring, a complementary manual strategy coding layer records the dominant legitimation strategy for each segment from a set of eight theoretically derived strategy types (self-defense and necessity; sovereignty and non-interference; denial and reinterpretation; moral and humanitarian framing; counter-terrorism and securitization; whataboutism and tu quoque; procedural-legal claims; historical and existential narratives). This layer follows the two analytical dimensions described in Section 2.3. The two coding layers – Habermas type from keyword classification; manual strategy type – capture different facets of the same speech act and are treated as complementary rather than redundant in the empirical analysis.

3.4.3. Historical Periodization

Each coded segment is additionally tagged with one of four historical sub-periods, defined by geopolitically significant inflection points rather than arbitrary temporal intervals:

- Cold War (1946–1989). The foundational decades of the postwar normative order, marked by superpower bipolarity and the ideological structuring of international legitimation discourse;
- Post–Cold War normative expansion (1990–2001). The transition to liberal internationalism's ascendancy, emergence of humanitarian intervention as a contested norm, and UNSC activism;
- Post-9/11 Security Turn (2002–2013). Beginning with UNSC Resolution 1373 (2001), which established counter-terrorism as a universal security obligation and created a new legitimation resource broadly available to state actors;
- Post-2014 Normative Fragmentation (2014–2023). Beginning with Russia's incorporation of Crimea, which General Assembly resolution 68/262 characterized as a violation of territorial integrity, and the subsequent fragmentation of the post-Cold War normative consensus.

This periodization allows the analysis to test H3 (temporal shift) and provides the temporal structure for the corpus-level H1 convergence analysis.

3.5. Statistical Methods

The quantitative dimension of the analysis employs a suite of statistical methods, selected to match the data structure (categorical, small-N, often with sparse cell frequencies) and the substantive questions being addressed.

Chi-square tests of independence (χ^2) are used to assess whether the distribution of Habermas action types differs significantly across blocs (H4) and across historical periods (H3). The chi-square statistic measures the deviation of observed cell frequencies from what would be expected if the two categorical variables were independent. Effect size is reported as Cramér's V, which normalizes chi-square for table dimensions and sample size. Given the small expected cell frequencies characteristic of the 33-case sample (many cells below the conventional threshold of 5), all chi-square results are accompanied by the percentage of cells with expected frequency below 5, and results with high proportions of such cells are interpreted with explicit caution.

Fisher's exact test is used for pairwise bloc comparisons, where the small sample sizes render chi-square approximations unreliable. Fisher's exact test computes the exact probability of observing the given contingency table or a more extreme one under the null hypothesis of independence, without relying on large-sample approximations. It is preferred over chi-square for 2×2 and small contingency tables with expected cell counts below 5.

Adjusted standardized residuals are used to identify which specific role-bloc combinations deviate most substantially from expected frequencies. Unlike raw residuals, adjusted residuals account for both the marginal totals of the row and column and the overall sample size, making comparisons across cells in the same table meaningful. Values exceeding ± 2 are interpreted as indicating statistically notable over- or under-representation.

Correspondence analysis (CA) provides a geometric representation of the association structure in a contingency table. CA decomposes the chi-square distance between row and column profiles via singular value decomposition (SVD), producing principal coordinates for both rows (communicative roles) and columns (blocs or periods) in a low-dimensional space. The proportion of total inertia (analogous to variance) captured by each dimension is reported via scree plots; dimensions capturing cumulatively more than 80 percent of total inertia are treated as the substantively meaningful space. CA was implemented via SVD in Python (numpy) without external dimensionality-reduction libraries, ensuring full procedural transparency.

One-way ANOVA is used to test whether the mean corpus-level keyword signal score for the counter-terrorism dimension differs significantly across the three blocs in the pre-2001 and post-2001 periods separately. ANOVA tests the null hypothesis that group means are equal; a non-significant result (both pre- and post-2001) is the predicted outcome under H1, indicating that adoption of counter-terrorism framing did not cluster in a single bloc.

Two-sample t-tests (independent samples) are used to assess whether the mean counter-terrorism signal score differs significantly between the pre-2001 and post-2001 periods within each bloc. This tests whether the post-9/11 shift detected in the case-level analysis is also present at the corpus level, across all bloc members – not only those in the 33-case sample.

3.6. Reliability, Validity, and Scope of Claims

Reliability is addressed through double-coding: a subset of the sample (approximately 20 percent of speeches) is independently coded by a trained research assistant working from the same codebook. Inter-coder reliability is calculated using Cohen's kappa, with $\kappa \geq 0.70$ treated as the study's pre-specified minimum acceptable threshold – a level corresponding to “substantial agreement” (Landis & Koch, 1977) in standard interpretive scales for kappa. Disagreements are resolved through discussion and codebook refinement. All disagreements and resolutions are documented in an audit trail.

Validity in directed content analysis depends on whether the coding categories adequately capture the phenomenon of interest. Construct validity is grounded in the theoretical derivation of the categories from Habermas (1984), operationalized through the IR applications in Risse (2000), Müller (2004), and Bjola (2005). Face validity is assessed through the pilot phase: if trained coders systematically struggle to assign segments to categories, this signals that category definitions require refinement.

Claims are appropriately bounded by the study's design. The analysis identifies and describes the distribution of legitimization strategies within the selected sample of speeches from states facing allegations of contested conduct; it does not claim that this distribution is representative of all UNGA speeches. The temporal dimension captures distributional shifts across the sample; no causal mechanisms are established. No adjudicative claims are made: coding a segment as deploying self-defense framing is not a finding that the state's action was or was not lawful. The object of analysis is justificatory discourse – how states publicly account for their conduct – not the legal or factual merits of those accounts.

Two further constraints apply. The corpus covers only the UNGA General Debate; legitimization strategies operative in the Security Council, bilateral diplomatic communications, or domestic political discourse fall outside the scope of analysis. Translation from non-English originals introduces the risk of

systematic distortion in cases where specific legal vocabulary is not fully preserved; the interpretive analysis flags this constraint where it is especially salient.

Subject to these constraints, the two-level analytical design produces a systematic and theoretically grounded account – adequate for the empirical analysis reported in Chapter 4.

4. Empirical Analysis

4.1. Sample Overview

The analytical sample comprises 33 case-years drawn from the Harvard UN General Debate Corpus (UNGDC), spanning 1956 to 2022. Each case-year represents a state-session in which (1) the government faced externally documented allegations of legally or normatively contested conduct, and (2) the corresponding UNGA General Debate speech contains textual material that addresses those allegations. The case identification procedure follows the criterion-based exhaustive logic described in Chapter 3: no predetermined N was fixed; rather, all speech-years satisfying both inclusion criteria were retained.

The 33 cases yield 102 coded segments in total. Ninety-seven of these segments were successfully classified by the Habermas-type keyword classifier; the remaining five – concentrated in the USA 1983 (Grenada), USA 2003 (Iraq, one segment), Myanmar 2017, Turkey 2019, and Russia 2008 (Georgia) speeches – returned scores of zero across all role dimensions and were coded as unclassified. The unclassified rate stands at 4.9 percent of the full sample (5/102). The practical significance of this figure is discussed in the methodological note below (Section 4.2). The composition of the case sample by historical period and geopolitical bloc is summarized in Table 4.1.

Table 4.1

Sample composition. 33 case-years by period and geopolitical bloc

Period	Western bloc	Soviet/Eastern bloc	Non-Aligned Movement
Cold War (1946–1989)	GBR 1956, USA 1965, USA 1983	RUS 1956, RUS 1968, VNM 1980, RUS 1980	ZAF 1960
Post–Cold War (1990–2001)	USA 1999	RUS 1995, RUS 2000	IRQ 1990, IDN 1992, CHN 1997, IRQ 1997, IDN 1999, YUG 2001
Post-9/11 Security Turn (2002–2013)	USA 2003, USA 2004, ISR 2006, ISR 2009	PRK 2006, RUS 2008	IRN 2011, SYR 2013
Post-2014 (2014–2023)	TUR 2019	AZE 2020, RUS 2014, RUS 2022	SAU 2015, CHN 2015, MMR 2017, ETH 2021

The distribution across periods is deliberately uneven, reflecting the underlying variation in the density of documented legitimization-relevant episodes across historical phases. The Post-9/11 period yields the largest volume of coded material (31 classified segments from 8 cases), as expected given that the counter-terrorism discursive frame generated a particularly high density of justificatory language across a range of actors and contexts. The Cold War period contributes the fewest classified segments (11 from 8 cases), partly because of the smaller number of states with documented allegations in the UNGDC for the 1946–1989 range, and partly because some Cold War-era passages proved harder to classify using a keyword-based approach calibrated primarily to post-1990 legitimization vocabulary.

Figure 4.1

Role Heatmap. Communicative Roles per Case-Year, Grouped by Habermas Type and Period

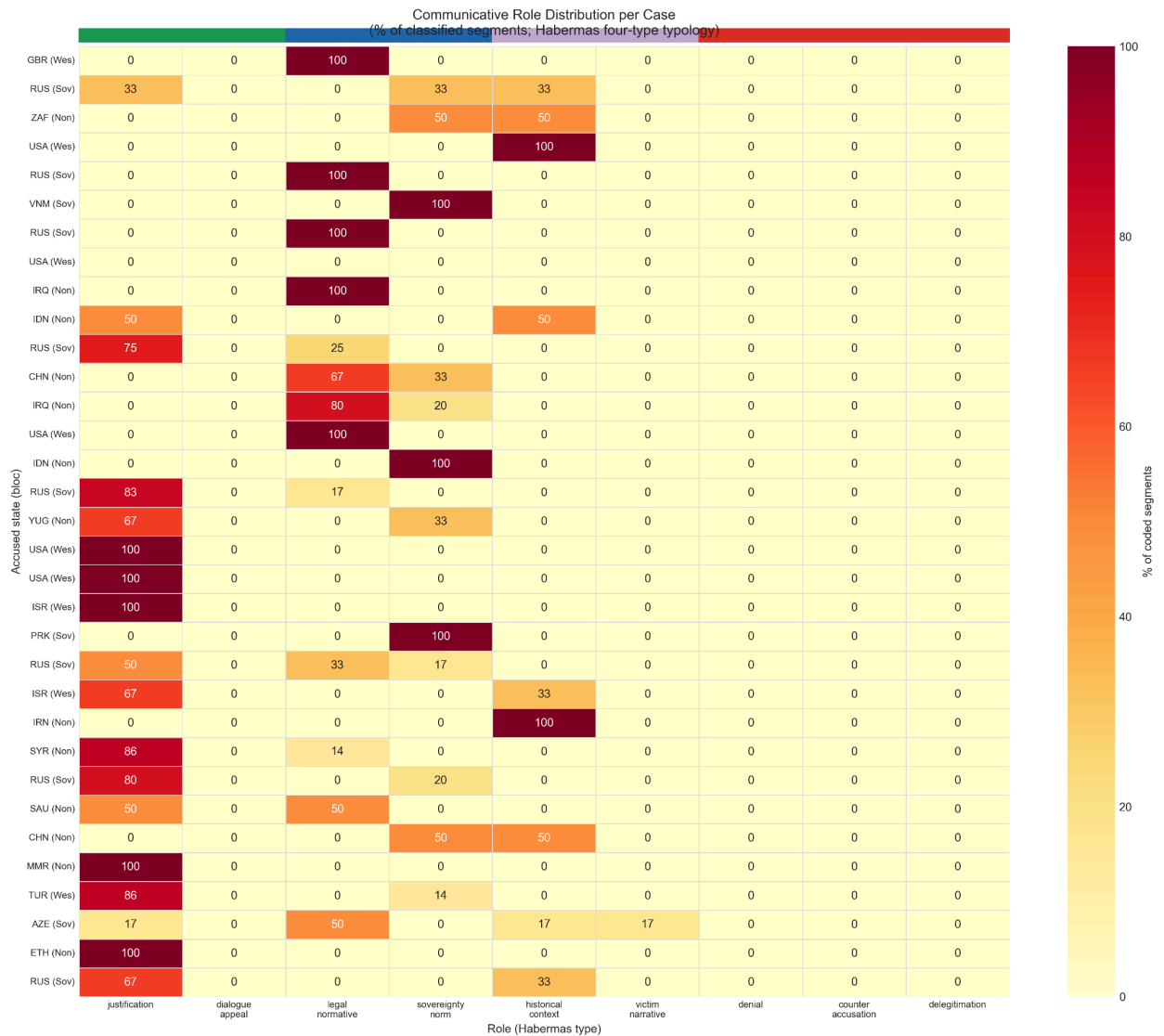


Figure 4.1 provides an overview of the full analytical sample: each row corresponds to one case-year; each column represents one of the nine communicative roles; the color intensity encodes the role's keyword density score. The banded background distinguishes the four Habermas action types. This figure functions as a reference panel for the case-level variation discussed in Section 4.4.

4.2. Analytical Architecture. Operationalization and Methodological Rationale

4.2.1. Habermas's Typology as a Coding Framework

The decision to apply Habermas's (1984) four-type taxonomy of social action – communicative, normative, dramaturgical, and strategic – as the master framework for classifying coded segments, rather than working from an inductively derived set of categories, follows the logic of directed qualitative content analysis (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005). The theory provides the initial categorization structure; the

data refine it. This approach is defensible here because the theoretical categories are sufficiently specified at the conceptual level to generate operational distinctions, and because prior IR scholarship has consistently found Habermas's typology applicable to multilateral diplomatic discourse (Risse, 2000; Bjola, 2005; Müller, 2004).

The mapping from nine communicative roles to four Habermas action types was constructed deductively:

- Communicative action (oriented toward *Verständigung*, reaching understanding through reasons). Covers the roles of *justification* (presenting reasons why the action was necessary or defensible) and *dialogue_appeal* (directly seeking interlocutors' reasoned engagement). These roles share the validity claim of truth – the speaker presents propositional content as factually or normatively accurate and invites rational assessment;
- Normative action (oriented toward *Richtigkeit*, norm-conformity). Covers *legal_normative* (explicit invocation of international legal instruments – the UN Charter, UNSC resolutions, treaty provisions) and *sovereignty_norm* (appeals to the principle of non-interference as a binding norm). These roles assert rightness – the speaker positions the action as consistent with a binding normative standard shared by the audience;
- Dramaturgical action (oriented toward *Wahrhaftigkeit*, self-presentation as authentic). Covers *historical_context* (contextualizing the action within a narrative of prior injustice or historical claim) and *victim_narrative* (presenting the state as the injured party). These roles stage sincerity – the speaker constructs a presentation of the situation that positions the self's motives as genuine and the action as emotionally and morally comprehensible;
- Strategic action (oriented toward success, not mutual understanding): covers *denial*, *counter_accusation*, and *delegitimation*. These roles involve no claim to shared normative ground; the speaker moves to remove the accusation rather than address it.

This four-part structure permits the analysis to ask not only which strategies appear, but what kind of legitimation work they perform – whether states construct shared reasons, invoke shared norms, display authentic self-presentation, or attempt to shut down the legitimation game entirely.

4.2.2. Cold War Bloc Construction and Block Transitions

The choice to structure the geopolitical comparison around Cold War institutional blocs – rather than, for instance, UN regional groups, regime type classifications, or contemporary alliance memberships – requires explicit justification.

Cold War bloc membership reflects shared institutional embeddedness during the period in which the foundational normative architecture of the postwar international order was being constructed and contested. States aligned with NATO and the Western alliance not only shared security arrangements but also participated in overlapping legal, economic, and diplomatic institutions that shaped a common normative vocabulary – one oriented toward liberal rules-based frameworks and, in later decades, human rights conditionality. States of the Soviet and Eastern bloc operated within a distinct normative context that privileged formal sovereignty, non-interference, and the legal primacy of the UN Charter as a check on Western interventionism. Non-Aligned Movement states, particularly through the Bandung framework and subsequent Group of 77 solidarities, constructed a third normative repertoire oriented simultaneously toward formal legal equality, anti-colonialism, and sovereignty protection (Prashad, 2007; Dinkel, 2019).

If legitimization strategies are shaped by normative context – by the standards of rightness that a speaker’s core audience treats as legitimate grounds – then bloc membership during the Cold War period should predict rhetorical patterns in ways that post-Cold War alliance configurations or regional groupings would not capture as cleanly.

A technical complication arises from the entry of fourteen Eastern European states into NATO after 1991. Treating Poland, Hungary, or Estonia as part of the Soviet/Eastern bloc in 2004 would misrepresent their normative affiliation. The analysis therefore implements period-aware bloc transitions: states retain their Soviet/Eastern bloc classification up to their year of NATO accession, after which they are reclassified as Western bloc members. Since none of the 14 transitioning states appear as case-years in the analytical sample, this coding rule does not affect the results reported here – but it preserves conceptual integrity and would matter significantly in any expanded analysis of the post-1999 Eastern European discourse.

4.2.3. Keyword Scoring and the Unclassified Segment Rate

Each coded segment is scored by computing keyword hit density across nine role-specific lexicons (hits per 1,000 words). The role with the highest non-zero score is assigned as the dominant role for that segment; segments with all-zero scores across all lexicons are designated unclassified. The overall unclassified rate is 4.9 percent. Within the Western bloc, the rate is notably higher at 11.1 percent (three segments from the nine Western cases). This asymmetry is analytically informative rather than merely methodological: Western diplomatic discourse, particularly from the United States and Israel, frequently employs more institutionally indirect and hedged language than the more direct sovereignty or legal invocations characteristic of Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned speeches. A segment that constructs a justificatory argument through elaborate subordinate clauses and conditional framings may be harder to

classify by keyword frequency than one that straightforwardly asserts non-interference. The higher unclassified rate in the Western subcorpus can therefore be read as a trace of a different rhetorical register – one that operates through implication and institutional framing rather than explicit lexical assertion.

4.3. Aggregate Distribution of Communicative Action Types

Across all 97 classified segments, communicative action is the most prevalent Habermas type, accounting for 50 segments (51.5 percent). Normative action follows at 35 segments (36.1 percent). Dramaturgical action appears in 12 segments (12.4 percent). Strategic action – denial, counter-accusation, and delegitimation – is entirely absent from the classified sample (zero segments carry strategic action as their dominant mode). Figure 4.2 summarizes this aggregate distribution by bloc.

Figure 4.2

Habermas Action Types by Cold War Bloc

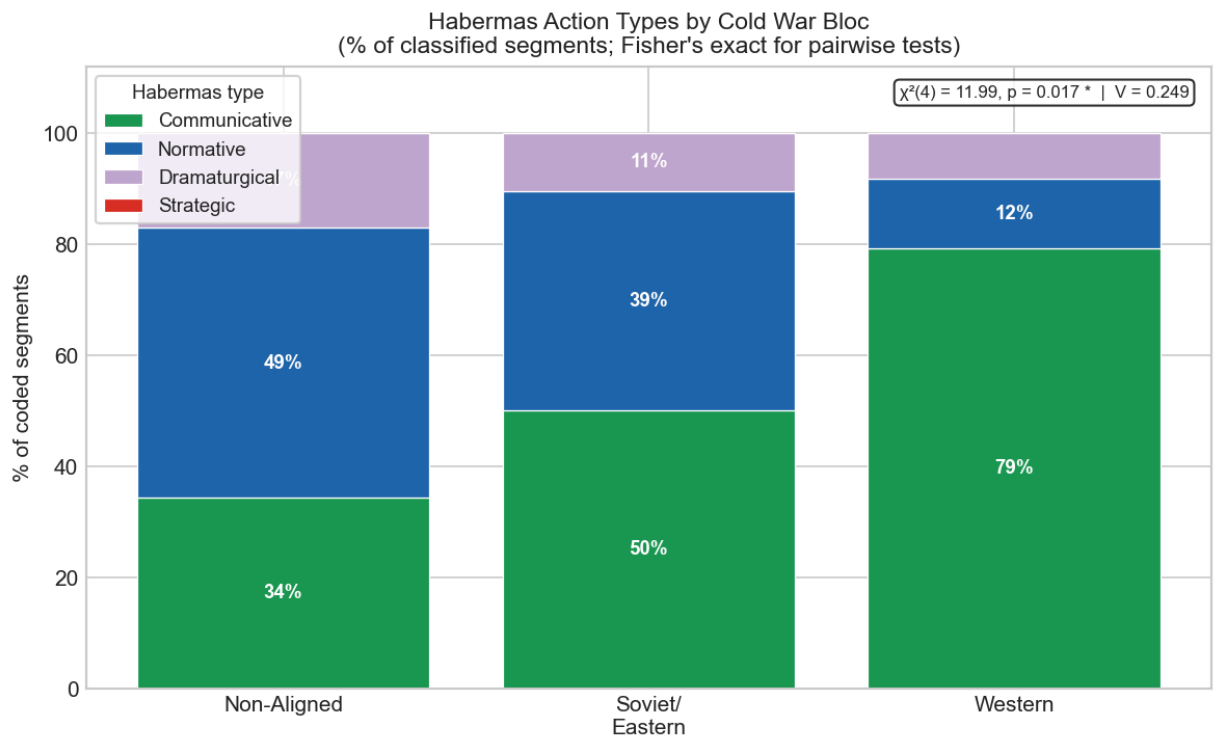
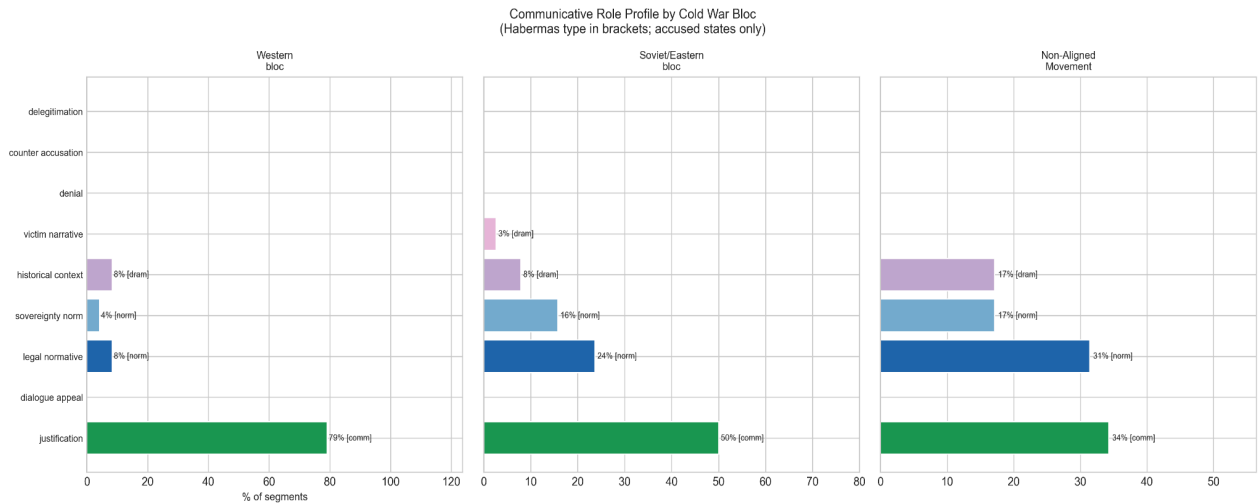


Figure 4.3

Role Distribution by Bloc. Nine Communicative Roles



Note. Bars show the percentage of classified segments assigned to each communicative role within each Cold War bloc. Labels in brackets indicate the corresponding Habermas action type.

As shown in Figure 4.3, the three strategic roles – denial, counter-accusation, and delegitimation – do not appear as dominant modes in any bloc. This complete absence of strategic action requires comment. The three strategic roles do appear in the manually coded segmentation layer (the `manual_strategy_code` field), but not as dominant modes in any classified segment. Every segment, including those that might colloquially be described as deflection or counter-attack, contains sufficient justificatory or normative content to be classified under one of the other three types. This finding does not mean that states never attempt to shut down legitimation challenges through purely strategic moves; it does mean that in the UNGA forum, even the most adversarial speech acts are embedded within a legitimating frame of some kind. The forum’s institutional structure – its public character, universal membership, and founding normative architecture – appears to impose a minimum requirement of normative performance that keeps purely strategic speech acts absent from the classified sample, at least at the textual level. This observation provides preliminary support for H2.

At the level of manually coded strategies, the frequency distribution is summarized in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2

Distribution of Manually Coded Legitimation Strategies

Strategy	Frequency (n)	% of 102 segments
Counter-Terrorism & Securitization	35	34.3%
Procedural-Legal Claims	28	27.5%
Historical and Existential Narratives	12	11.8%

Strategy	Frequency (n)	% of 102 segments
Sovereignty and Non-Interference	10	9.8%
Whataboutism and Tu Quoque	9	8.8%
Moral and Humanitarian Framing	6	5.9%
Self-Defense and Necessity	1	1.0%
Denial and Reinterpretation	1	1.0%

Counter-terrorism framing and procedural-legal claims together account for 63 of 102 segments (61.8 percent), confirming their status as the dominant legitimization instruments across the corpus. The near-absence of explicit self-defense invocations (n=1) is a notable finding: despite Article 51 of the UN Charter being the primary legal instrument governing the use of force, states in the sample rarely invoke it directly. The more common pattern is to construct a necessity argument through counter-terrorism framing – establishing that the threat was existential and the response proportionate – without formally triggering the Article 51 architecture. This rhetorical displacement from legal to quasi-legal justificatory language supports Bjola’s (2005) account of deliberative legitimacy: states construct normative consensus through public argumentation outside and alongside formal legal channels, rather than simply asserting legal entitlements.

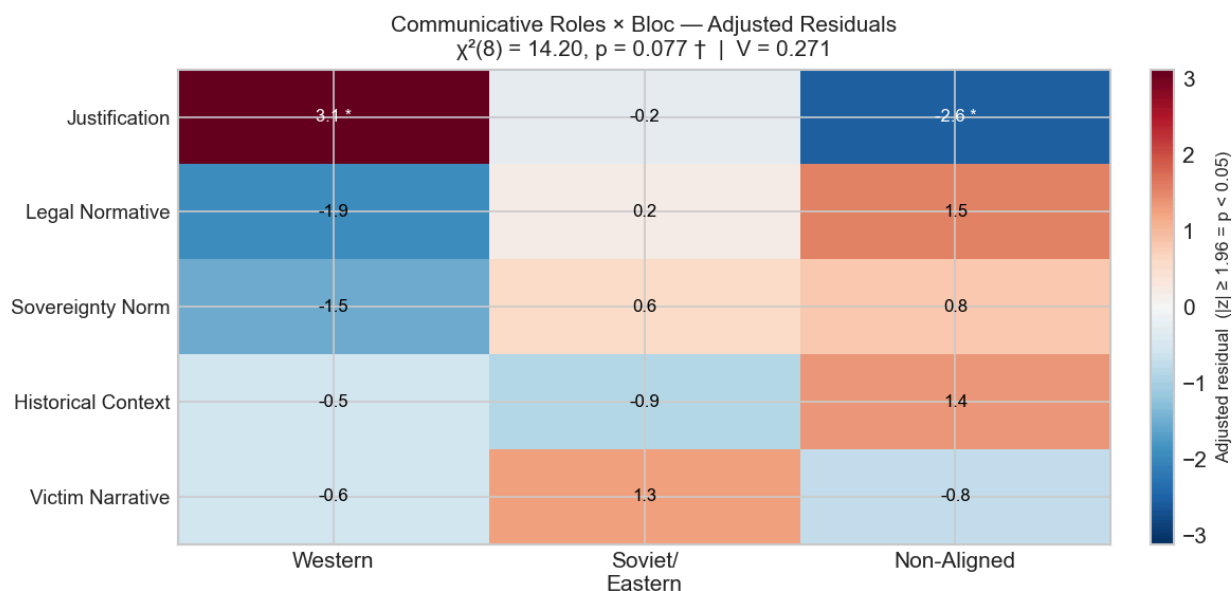
4.3.1. Co-occurrence. Strategy Pairings with Violation Types

The reduced co-occurrence matrix (available strategies × documented violation types) suggests that counter-terrorism framing is predominantly associated with use-of-force and human rights allegations – the two violation types most directly implicated in post-9/11 security discourse. Sovereignty and non-interference appeals cluster most strongly with territorial integrity violations. Procedural-legal claims appear across use-of-force cases but are less frequent in human rights or territorial integrity contexts. This patterning matches the expectation that different violation types activate different normative vocabularies: force-related cases require justificatory and procedural arguments; territory-related cases activate sovereignty norms; human rights cases draw on historical and counter-terrorism framings.

Although the preceding co-occurrence patterns describe strategy–violation pairings, the bloc-level residual structure reveals a separate pattern of geopolitical differentiation. Figure 4.4 shows the adjusted standardized residuals for communicative roles by Cold War bloc.

Figure 4.4

Adjusted Residuals Heatmap. Communicative Roles by Cold War Bloc



Note. Cells show adjusted standardized residuals from the communicative-role by bloc contingency table. Positive values indicate over-representation relative to expected frequencies; negative values indicate under-representation. Asterisks mark cells with $|z| \geq 1.96$.

As Figure 4.4 shows, the adjusted residuals heatmap reveals which role-bloc combinations diverge most substantially from expected frequencies. The justification role is most strongly over-represented in the Western bloc (positive residual), while legal_normative and sovereignty_norm are over-represented in the Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned blocs. The chi-square test for the roles × blocs contingency table yields $\chi^2(8) = 14.20, p = 0.077$, with 53 percent of cells having expected frequency below 5 – indicating that the result should be interpreted cautiously. Nevertheless, the directional pattern holds across multiple analytical layers, as the Fisher’s exact pairwise tests reported in Section 4.4 demonstrate.

4.4. Comparative Case Analysis

The quantitative mapping of communicative roles and action types identifies aggregate patterns; this section examines the rhetorical logic underlying the three most prevalent strategy types through close reading of representative cases. The cases were selected to illustrate how the dominant modes of legitimation are realized in practice – and to show that the aggregate category labels correspond to coherent argumentative strategies, not merely keyword co-occurrence.

4.4.1. Self-Defense, Necessity, and the Counter-Terrorism Frame

The most common legitimation pattern across the corpus is what the coding framework captures as justification – a communicative action mode in which the speaker constructs a case for the necessity, proportionality, or defensive character of the contested action through propositional argument rather than

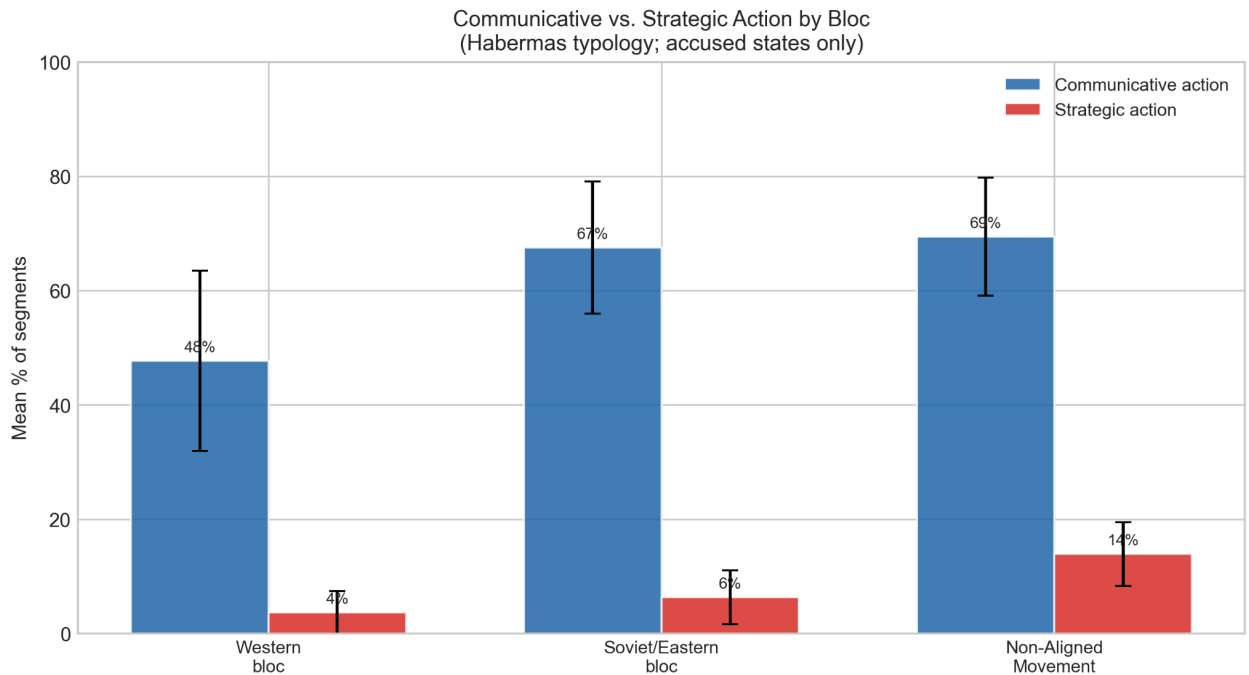
pure norm invocation. This communicative mode dominates the Western bloc (19 of 24 classified Western segments, 79.2 percent) and is also the single most frequent type in the Soviet/Eastern bloc (19 of 38 classified segments, 50.0 percent).

The rhetorical structure of justification-dominant speeches follows a recognizable pattern. The speaker first establishes the nature and severity of the threat; then identifies the action taken as a necessary and proportionate response; then frames the action as consistent with the right of self-defense or collective security obligations, without necessarily invoking the specific Article 51 language. Turkey's 2019 speech on Operation Peace Spring in northeast Syria illustrates this structure. Of the 8 coded segments, 7 were classified, and 6 of those 7 fall under the justification role (86 percent of classified segments). The argument is structured around two claims: that PKK and YPG activities across the Syrian border constituted an active terrorist threat to Turkish territory and population, and that Operation Peace Spring was a proportionate response in conformity with the right of self-defense and relevant UN Security Council resolutions. The word "terrorism" and its morphological variants appear at high keyword density throughout the relevant passages. The explicit Article 51 invocation appears only once; the burden of the argument is carried instead by the counter-terrorism frame.

This pattern – necessity argument through counter-terrorism framing, with legal invocation as support rather than primary vehicle – appears consistently across the post-9/11 sample. Israel's speeches on the Second Lebanon War (2006) and Operation Cast Lead (2009), the United States' address following the Abu Ghraib allegations (2004), and Russia's speeches on the First and Second Chechen conflicts (1995, 2000) all follow this architecture. Russia's 2000 address responds to allegations of civilian harm during the Second Chechen campaign by setting out the government's account of the conflict: 83 percent of its classified content falls in the justification role, presenting the operation as a necessary counter-terrorism response to internationally organized armed groups and citing the post-1999 Chechen bombings as the immediate precipitating context that rendered the action unavoidable. In this sense, the discursive logic of the "war on terror" was already operationally present in Russian UNGA rhetoric before September 2001, which the post-9/11 institutionalization of counter-terrorism discourse subsequently extended to a much wider range of actors. Figure 4.5 summarizes the contrast between communicative and strategic action across Cold War blocs.

Figure 4.5

Communicative and Strategic Action by Cold War Bloc



Note. Bars show the mean percentage of classified segments assigned to communicative and strategic action within each bloc. Error bars indicate variation across case-years.

The Syria 2013 case – the Assad government’s address following allegations of chemical weapons use in Eastern Ghouta – provides a counterpoint. Of 7 classified segments, 85.7 percent fall under justification (communicative), but the content of the argument is not self-defense in the conventional sense. The speaker denies that the government forces deployed chemical weapons and attributes the incident to opposition actors, framing the entire episode as a fabricated pretext for external intervention. The justification is thus oriented toward constructing an alternative factual account rather than defending the original action. This illustrates that the communicative Habermas type captures a family of justification strategies, not a single rhetorical form.

4.4.2. Normative-Legal Invocations: Charter Appeals and Sovereignty Framing

The second major cluster – normative action – is most pronounced in the Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned Movement blocs. Of the 38 classified Soviet/Eastern segments, 15 (39.5 percent) are coded as normative; of the 35 Non-Aligned segments, 17 (48.6 percent). By contrast, only 3 of 24 Western classified segments (12.5 percent) fall under this type.

Within the normative cluster, two sub-roles carry distinct rhetorical weight. Legal_normative invocations – direct citation of treaty provisions, Charter articles, or UNSC resolution language – appear most frequently in the Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern blocs: 11 and 9 segments respectively, compared to 2 in the Western subcorpus. Sovereignty_norm invocations – appeals to the non-interference principle

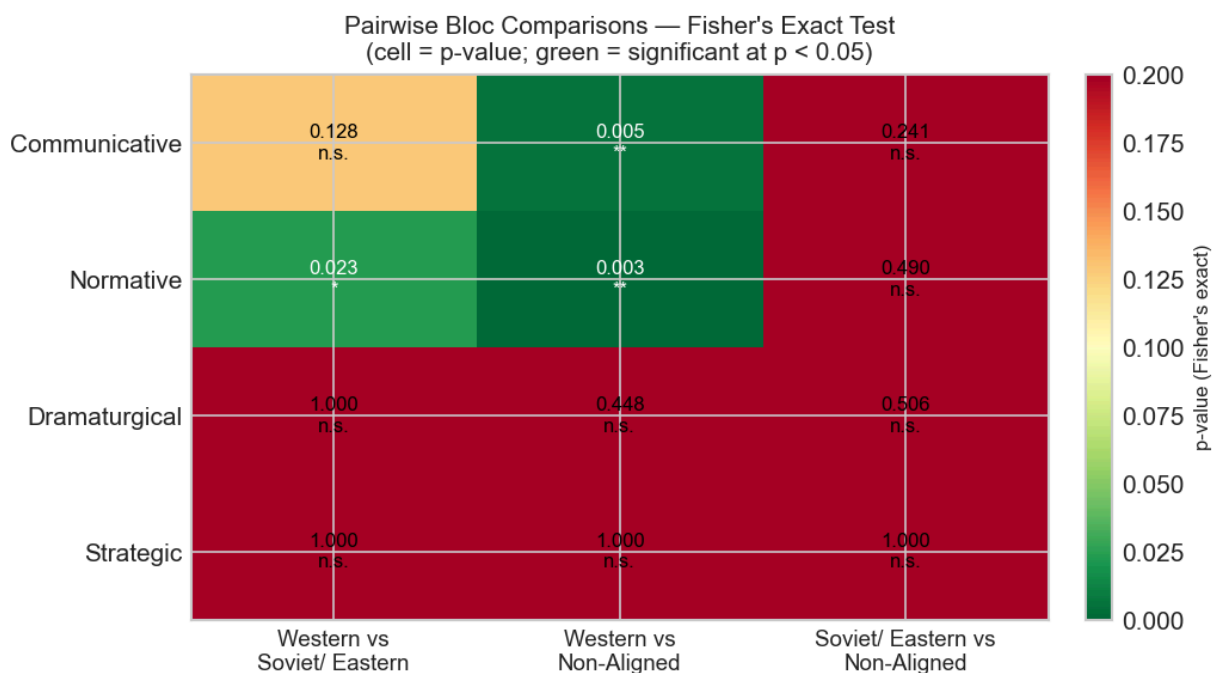
as a binding norm – show a similar distributional pattern: 6 and 6 segments respectively in the Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern blocs, against 1 in the Western subcorpus.

Iraq's 1990 speech, delivered in the immediate aftermath of the intervention in Kuwait, offers a concentrated illustration of normative-legal framing. All three coded segments are classified as *legal_normative* (normative action type), with the speaker grounding the argument in an extended interpretation of UNSC resolutions, historical treaty rights, and claims about the legal status of Kuwait relative to Iraqi territorial jurisdiction. The argument does not construct a counter-terrorism narrative; it constructs a legal claim. China's 1997 speech on Tibet and Xinjiang concentrates 67 percent of its classified content in *legal_normative* and 33 percent in *sovereignty_norm*, producing a two-pronged normative defense: the matters are legally internal to Chinese sovereignty, and external commentary constitutes an impermissible interference.

Vietnam's 1980 speech on the military presence in Cambodia presents an analytically interesting case of normative action at the border of the normative and dramaturgical types. Both coded segments are classified under *sovereignty_norm*, but the content of the norm invoked is the right of Cambodia to invite fraternal assistance – a normative claim about the legal character of the intervention rather than a straightforward non-interference appeal. The argument inverts the usual structure: rather than defending Vietnam's conduct by asserting its own sovereignty, the speaker defends it by asserting Cambodia's normative invitation. This inverted sovereignty argument is structurally similar to the Soviet defense of the intervention in Czechoslovakia (1968), where the *legal_normative* role carries a parallel argument about the Warsaw Pact's collective security obligations.

Figure 4.6

Pairwise Fisher's Exact Tests: Habermas Type Comparisons Across Blocs



Note. Cells show p-values from pairwise Fisher's exact tests comparing Habermas action-type distributions across blocs. Green cells indicate statistically significant differences at $p < .05$; n.s. indicates non-significant comparisons.

As shown in Figure 4.6, the pairwise Fisher's exact tests quantify the bloc-level differentiation in normative framing. The Western bloc is significantly less likely to deploy normative action relative to both the Soviet/Eastern bloc ($OR = 0.20$, $p = .023$) and the Non-Aligned Movement ($OR = 0.14$, $p = .003$). Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states are not significantly differentiated from each other ($p = .490$). This pattern – Western distinctness against a backdrop of Soviet/Non-Aligned similarity – provides the core empirical content for the assessment of H4.

4.4.3 Historical and Dramaturgical Registers

Dramaturgical action – oriented toward constructing an authentic self-presentation rather than toward legal argumentation or factual justification – is the least frequent Habermas type in the sample (12 segments, 12.4 percent), but its distribution reveals a meaningful pattern. The Non-Aligned Movement carries the highest share: 6 of 35 classified NAM segments (17.1 percent), compared to 4 of 38 (10.5 percent) in the Soviet/Eastern subcorpus and 2 of 24 (8.3 percent) in the Western subcorpus.

The two dramaturgical roles – *historical_context* and *victim_narrative* – tend to appear in cases where the contested action is framed as a response to a longer historical wrong rather than a discrete security threat. South Africa's 1960 speech on apartheid-era human rights allegations concentrates 50

percent of its classified content in the *historical_context* role, constructing a narrative of national development and civilizational transition that contextualizes international criticism as an interference with an ongoing internal process. Iran's 2011 speech on the IAEA findings concerning its nuclear programme concentrates all classified content in *historical_context*, situating the dispute within a broader narrative of Western technological imperialism and Iran's sovereign right to peaceful nuclear development.

The *victim_narrative* role appears in isolated cases where the accused state reframes itself as the injured party: Azerbaijan's 2020 speech on the Second Nagorno-Karabakh conflict (16.7 percent *victim_narrative*) illustrates the rhetorical mechanics of victim repositioning: by foregrounding what the speaker characterizes as decades of prior Armenian conduct in Nagorno-Karabakh, the address reframes the initiating actor in the military exchange as a respondent – displacing the normative question of who initiated force onto a prior grievance narrative and thereby converting a justification of offensive action into an account of defensive necessity, and Israel's 2009 speech on Operation Cast Lead (33.3 percent *historical_context* alongside 66.7 percent justification). The structural logic holds across these cases: the state does not primarily deny the alleged conduct but claims it was a response to prior victimization, thereby repositioning the normative burden of justification onto the accusing parties.

4.5. Temporal Dynamics: Strategy Evolution and the H3 Assessment

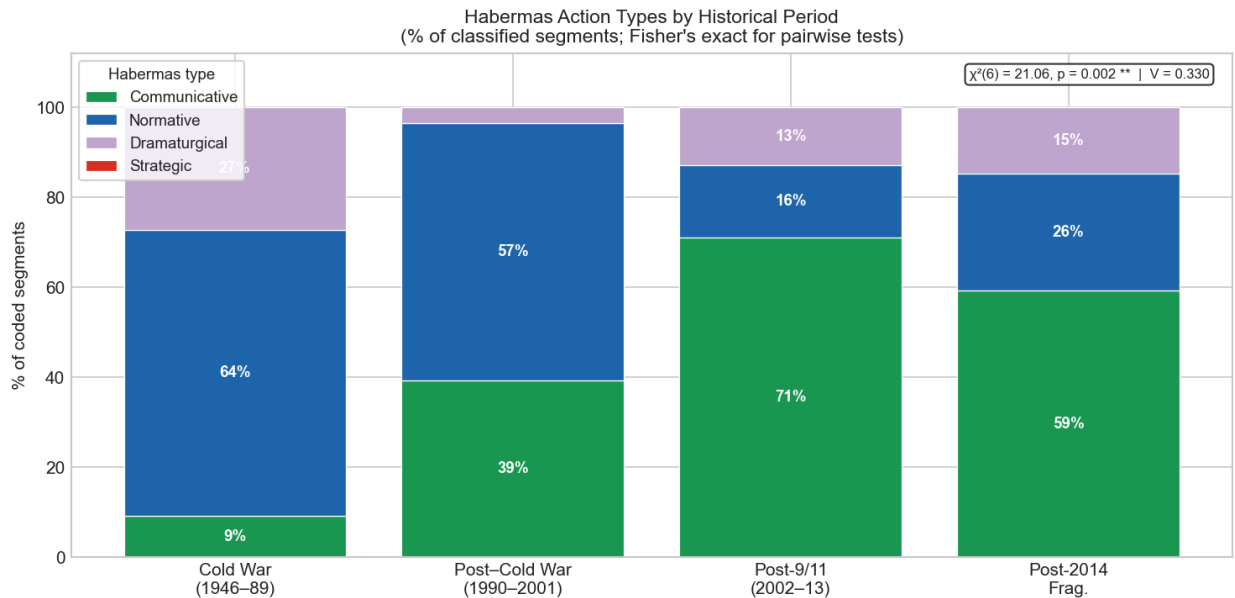
The temporal structure of the sample – four historical periods defined by geopolitical turning points rather than arbitrary intervals – allows the analysis to trace whether legitimization strategies are historically stable or whether they shift in response to structural changes in the normative environment of international relations.

The periodization is constructed as follows. The Cold War period (1946–1989) captures the foundational decades of the postwar order, marked by superpower rivalry and a relatively stable, if contested, distribution of normative authority between the UN system's legal framework and the ideological blocs that operated alongside it. The Post–Cold War period (1990–2001) marks the transition to a normatively more fluid order in which liberal internationalism expanded its claims, humanitarian intervention emerged as a contested norm, and the UN Security Council became an active (if inconsistent) enforcement body. The Post-9/11 Security Turn (2002–2013) begins with the September 2001 attacks and UNSC Resolution 1373 (2001), which established counter-terrorism as a global security obligation and provided a new legitimization resource to a diverse range of state actors. The Post-2014 Normative Fragmentation period begins with Russia's incorporation of Crimea in 2014 – which the majority of UN member states characterized as annexation in General Assembly resolution 68/262 – and the subsequent intensification of sovereignty-revisionist rhetoric – a period in which the normative consensus of the

1990s visibly fractured. Figure 4.7 summarizes the distribution of Habermas action types across the four historical periods.

Figure 4.7

Habermas Action Types by Historical Period



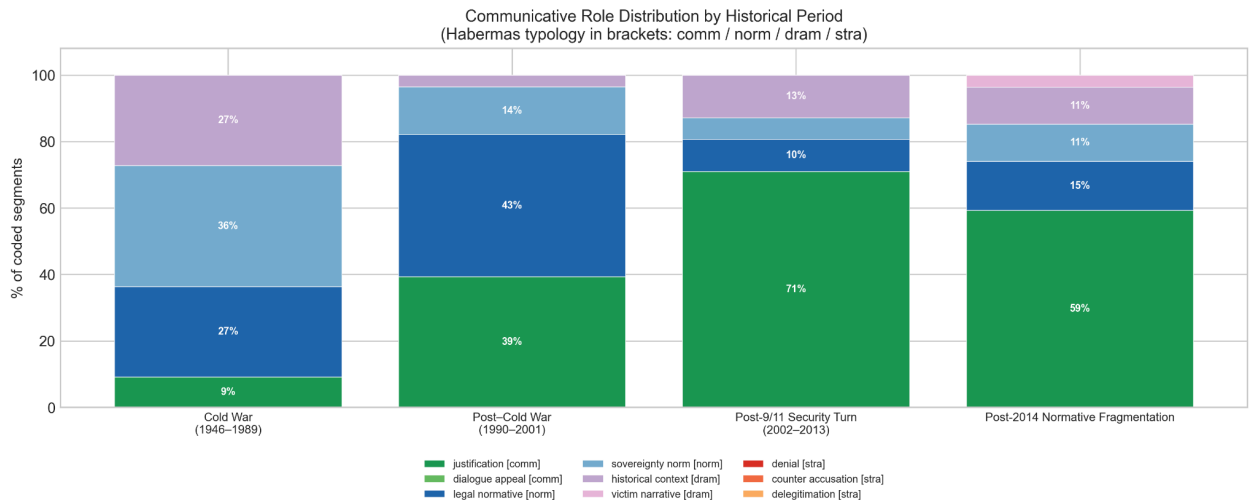
Note. Bars show the percentage of classified segments assigned to each Habermas action type within each historical period. The annotation reports the chi-square test of independence and Cramér's V for the period $\times$ action-type contingency table.

As shown in Figure 4.7, the distributional shift across periods is statistically significant: $\chi^2(6) = 21.06$, $p = .0018$, with Cramér's $V = .33$ indicating a moderate effect size. During the Cold War period, normative action dominates (7 of 11 classified segments, 63.6 percent), with communicative action accounting for only 9.1 percent. This fits a discursive environment in which formal legal argumentation – Charter invocations, sovereignty norms – is the dominant mode of legitimation in the Cold War sample. In the Post-Cold War period, normative action remains dominant but its share decreases (16 of 28, 57.1 percent) while communicative action rises substantially (11 of 28, 39.3 percent). The Post-9/11 period marks a decisive reversal: communicative action surges to 71.0 percent of classified content (22 of 31 segments), while normative action falls to 16.1 percent. In the Post-2014 period, the pattern partially stabilizes – communicative action remains dominant at 59.3 percent, but normative action recovers to 25.9 percent, suggesting that the sovereignty-revisionist framing of this era re-activated legal and normative argumentation alongside the justification register.

At the level of communicative roles, the temporal shift is especially visible in the changing balance between justification, legal-normative invocation, sovereignty norms, and historical framing. Figure 4.8 summarizes the distribution of communicative roles across the four historical periods.

Figure 4.8

Communicative Role Distribution Across Historical Periods



Note. Bars show the percentage of classified segments assigned to each communicative role within each historical period. Bracketed labels in the legend indicate the corresponding Habermas action type.

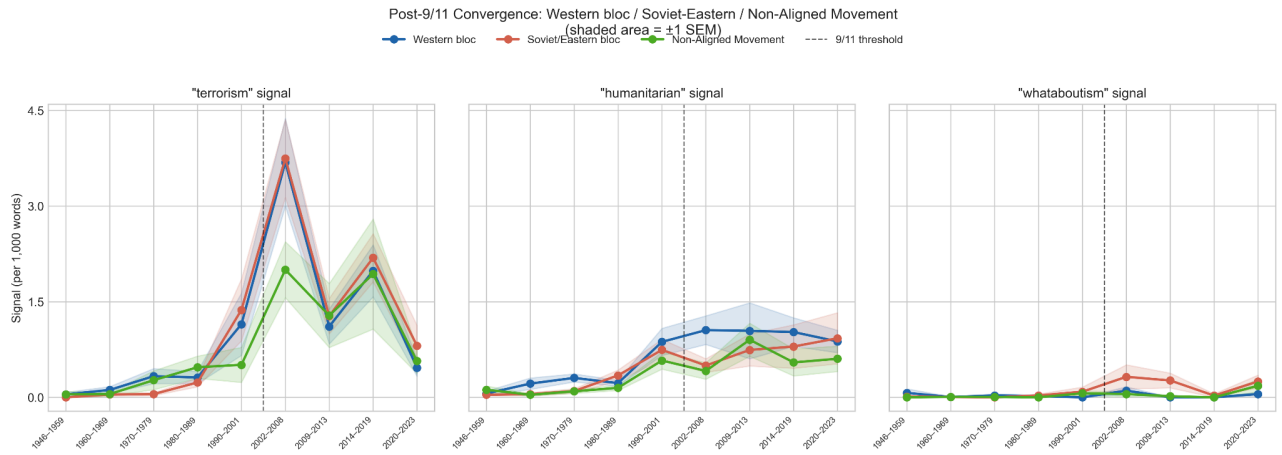
As shown in Figure 4.8, these findings provide clear support for H3 (temporal shift). The distribution of legitimation strategies is not stable across the period studied; it shifts in ways that are both statistically significant and theoretically interpretable. The 9/11 inflection point functions not merely as a geopolitical event but as a discursive turning point that reconfigured the normative vocabulary available to state actors seeking to justify contested actions before a universal audience.

4.5.1. The Corpus-Level Convergence Test: H1 Assessment

The Habermas-type analysis of the 33-case analytical sample captures the rhetoric of states already identified as facing contested conduct allegations. To test H1 – which concerns whether counter-terrorism framing converged *across blocs* after 2001 rather than being adopted selectively by one bloc – the analysis draws on the wider corpus-level dataset: keyword signal scores computed across a random sample of non-case-year speeches, enabling pre/post-2001 comparisons that are not confounded by the case selection criterion. Figure 4.9 shows the temporal evolution of selected corpus-level keyword signals by Cold War bloc.

Figure 4.9

Temporal Evolution of Selected Keyword Signals by Cold War Bloc

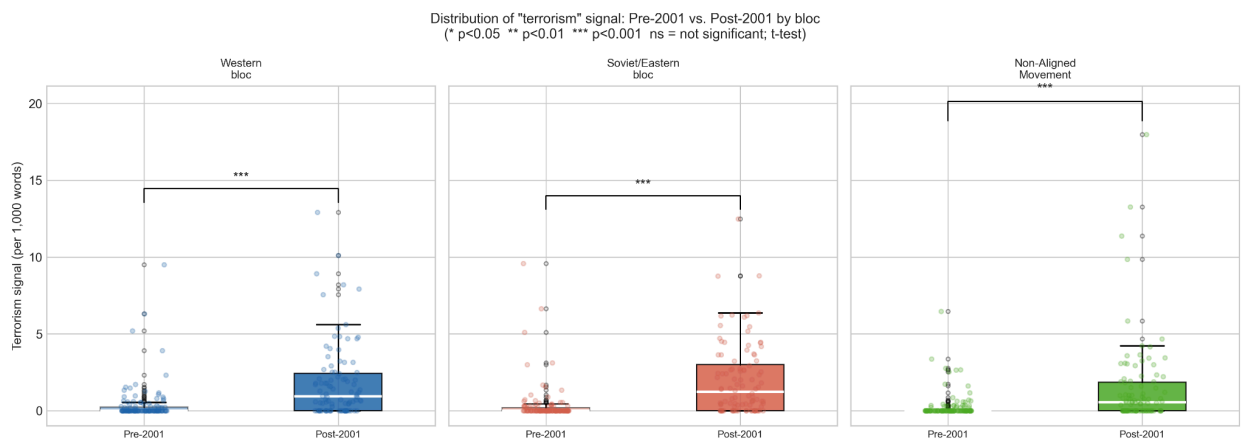


Note. Lines show mean keyword signal scores per 1,000 words by Cold War bloc across historical periods. Shaded areas represent ± 1 standard error of the mean. The dashed vertical line marks the 9/11 threshold.

Figure 4.11 then tests the pre/post-2001 shift in the counter-terrorism signal within each bloc.

Figure 4.10

Pre-2001 Versus Post-2001 Counter-Terrorism Signal by Bloc



Note. Box plots show the distribution of the counter-terrorism keyword signal before and after 2001 within each bloc. Brackets indicate two-sample t-test significance levels.

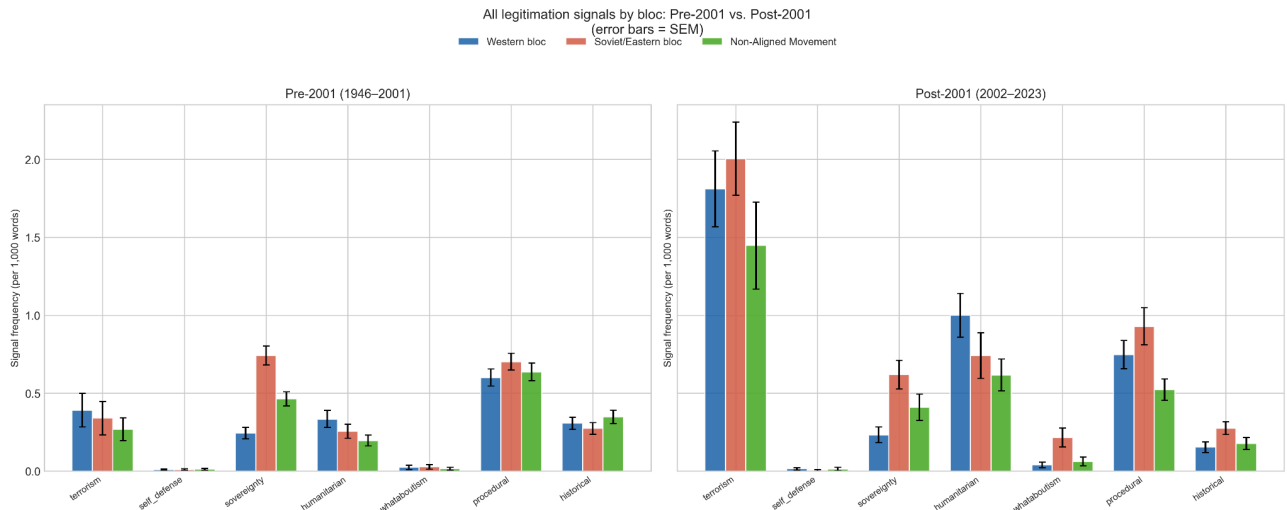
As shown in Figure 4.10, all three blocs exhibit a statistically significant post-2001 increase in the counter-terrorism signal. One-way ANOVA of the counter-terrorism signal across blocs in the pre-2001 period yields $F = 0.39$, $p = 0.678$, indicating no substantial inter-bloc differentiation before

September 2001. One-way ANOVA in the post-2001 period yields $F = 1.25$, $p = 0.288$, also not significant, confirming that post-2001 adoption of counter-terrorism framing is not concentrated in any single bloc. Two-sample t tests for the pre/post difference within each bloc are all significant at $p < 0.001$: Western, Soviet/Eastern, and Non-Aligned Movement blocs all show a statistically significant increase in counter-terrorism keyword density after 2001.

Both tests point in the same direction: the post-9/11 adoption of counter-terrorism framing is universal rather than bloc-specific. H1 is supported. The ideational convergence in the counter-terrorism lexicon, observed across states with divergent strategic interests and normative traditions, supports the argument that September 2001 created a new legitimization resource that was rapidly adopted across the international system – not because all states shared the same security interests, but because the discursive frame it provided was normatively available and rhetorically flexible enough to accommodate a wide range of contested actions. Figure 4.11 summarizes the pre- and post-2001 shift across all seven legitimization signals by Cold War bloc.

Figure 4.11

Seven Legitimation Signals by Cold War Bloc: Pre- and Post-2001 Comparison



Note. Bars show mean keyword signal frequencies per 1,000 words by Cold War bloc before and after 2001. Error bars indicate ± 1 standard error of the mean.

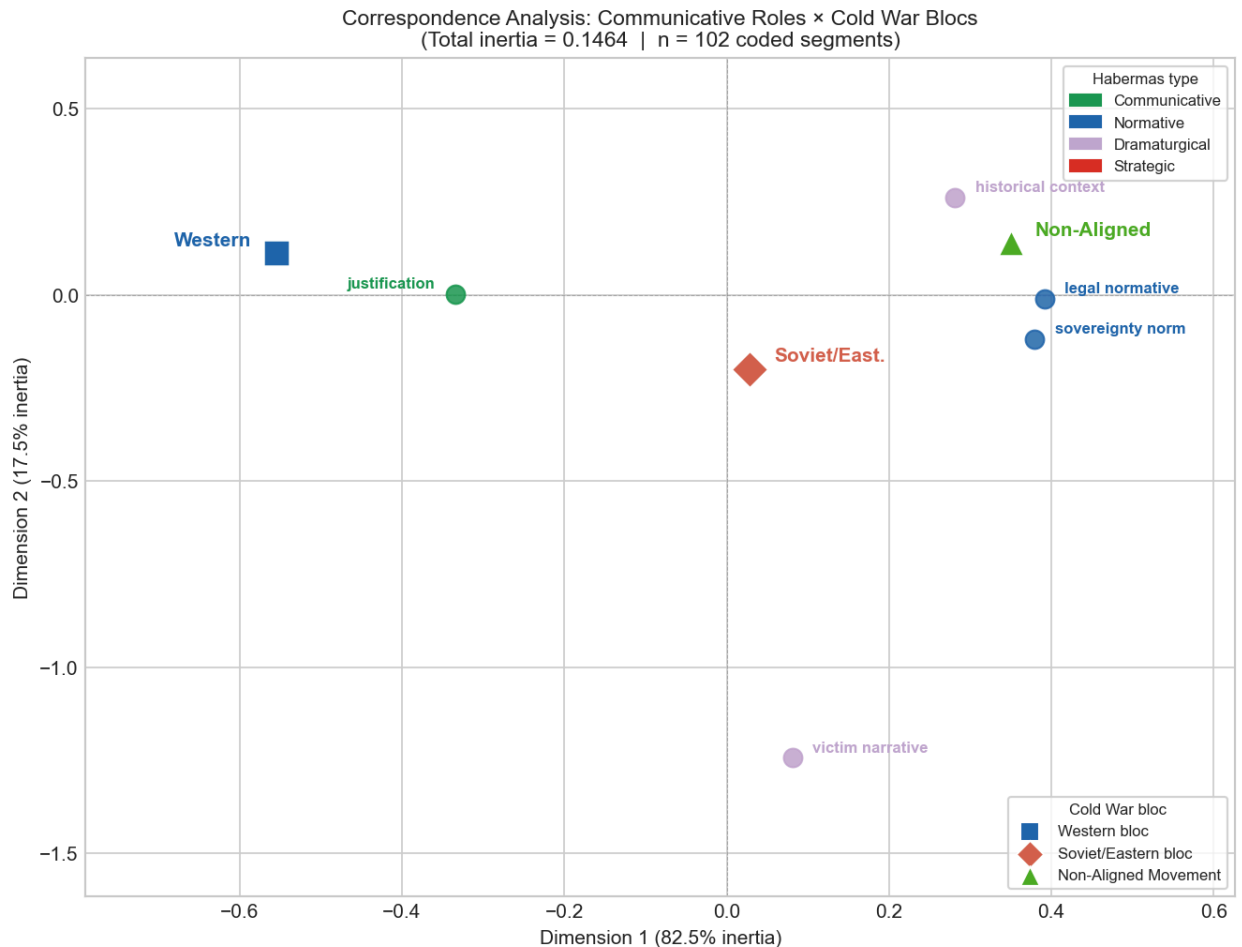
4.6. Geopolitical Bloc Differentiation. The H4 Assessment

Correspondence analysis (CA) provides a spatial representation of the association structure between communicative roles and Cold War blocs, complementing the chi-square and Fisher's exact results with a geometric account of how roles and blocs relate in the low-dimensional space of the

contingency table. Figure 4.12 visualizes the role–bloc association structure in the correspondence-analysis space.

Figure 4.12

Correspondence Analysis Biplot. Communicative Roles × Cold War Blocs

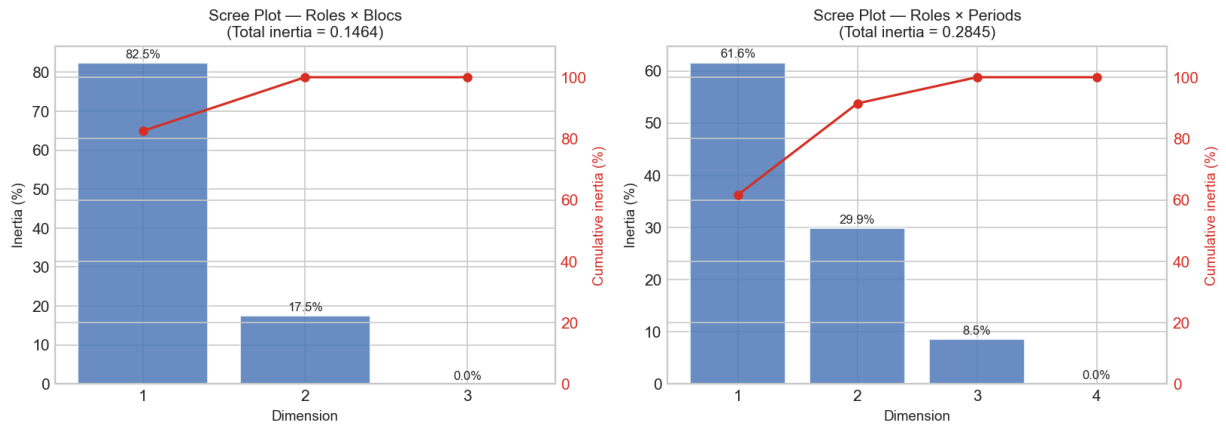


Note. Points represent row and column coordinates from correspondence analysis. Colored role markers indicate Habermas action types; bloc markers indicate Cold War bloc categories. Dimension 1 captures 82.5% of inertia, and Dimension 2 captures 17.5%.

Figure 4.13 reports the inertia decomposition used to assess how many correspondence-analysis dimensions are substantively meaningful.

Figure 4.13

Scree Plots for Correspondence Analysis. Roles × Blocs and Roles × Periods



Note. Bars show the share of inertia explained by each correspondence-analysis dimension. The red line shows cumulative inertia.

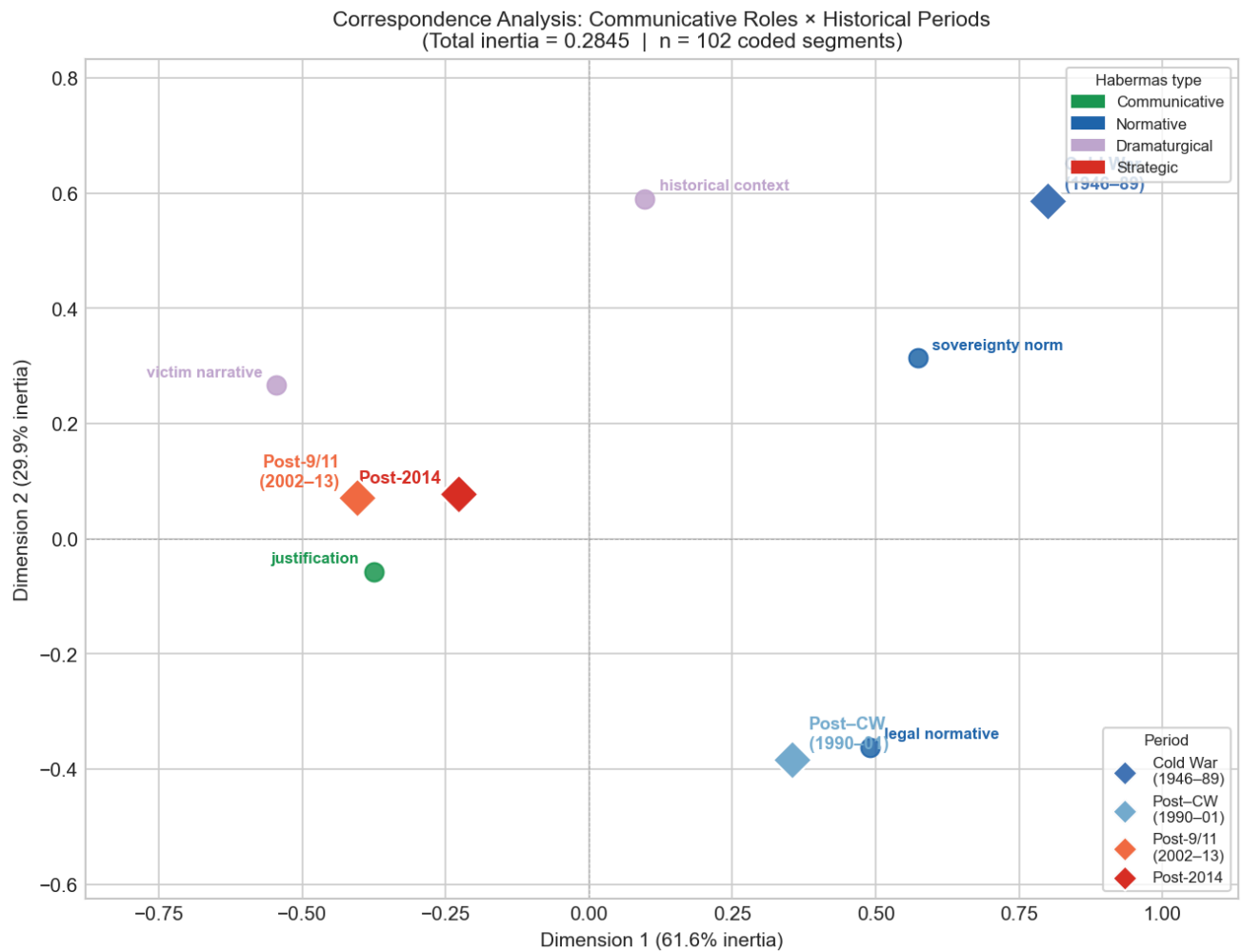
As shown in Figure 4.13, the CA for communicative roles by bloc decomposes 82.5 percent of total inertia on the first dimension – a concentration indicating that bloc differentiation is substantially one-dimensional. The Western bloc loads strongly negative on Dimension 1 (coordinate = -0.555), while the Non-Aligned Movement loads positive (+0.350) and the Soviet/Eastern bloc is near the origin (+0.028). Among roles, *justification* loads negative on Dimension 1 (-0.334), co-locating it with the Western bloc, while *legal_normative* (+0.392) and *sovereignty_norm* (+0.379) load positive, co-locating with the Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern blocs. *Historical_context* occupies an intermediate position (+0.281 on Dim 1, +0.263 on Dim 2), somewhat closer to the Non-Aligned Movement’s dramaturgical profile. The *victim_narrative* role has an extreme coordinate on Dimension 2 (-1.243), indicating that its association with a specific bloc (isolated cases in the Soviet/Eastern subcorpus) is an outlier pattern rather than a systematic one.

The spatial picture is clear: the primary axis of differentiation in the data separates states that legitimize primarily through *justification* (Western bloc) from states that legitimize primarily through *legal_normative* and *sovereignty_norm* invocations (Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern). This is not a difference in the overall willingness to engage in legitimation work – all blocs perform legitimation, and none defaults to strategic action. Rather, it is a difference in the *register* of legitimation: Western states construct arguments about necessity and proportionality, while non-Western states assert their actions’ conformity with binding legal norms.

To check whether the same role structure also appears along the temporal dimension, Figure 4.14 presents the correspondence-analysis biplot for communicative roles by historical period.

Figure 4.14

Correspondence Analysis Biplot: Communicative Roles × Historical Periods



Note. Points represent row and column coordinates from correspondence analysis. Colored role markers indicate Habermas action types; period markers indicate historical periods. Dimension 1 captures 61.6% of inertia, and Dimension 2 captures 29.9%.

As shown in Figure 4.14, the temporal correspondence-analysis space separates the Cold War period from the post-9/11 and post-2014 periods. The Cold War period is positioned closer to normative roles, while the post-9/11 and post-2014 periods cluster nearer to justification, reflecting the temporal shift documented in H3. The bloc-level tests nevertheless remain the main evidentiary basis for H4.

The chi-square test for Habermas action types by bloc yields $\chi^2(4) = 11.99$, $p = 0.017$, with Cramér's $V = 0.249$. The proportion of cells with expected frequency below five (33.3 percent) warrants caution; the Fisher's exact pairwise tests provide a more reliable basis for inference given the cell size constraints.

The pairwise comparisons (Fisher's exact) directly support H4:

- Western vs. Soviet/Eastern bloc, normative action. *odds ratio* = 0.20, $p = 0.023$. Western states are significantly less likely to invoke normative-legal action relative to Soviet/Eastern states;
- Western vs. Non-Aligned Movement, normative action. *odds ratio* = 0.14, $p = 0.003$. The Western bloc's deficit in normative-legal framing is even more pronounced relative to NAM states;
- Western vs. Non-Aligned Movement, communicative action. *odds ratio* = 4.75, $p = 0.005$. Western states are significantly more likely to deploy communicative (justification-oriented) action than Non-Aligned states.
- Soviet/Eastern vs. Non-Aligned Movement. No pairwise comparison reaches significance for any Habermas type (all $p > 0.18$), confirming that these two blocs are not meaningfully differentiated from each other in their legitimation registers.

H4 is supported. Western states occupy a distinct rhetorical position in the legitimation space: characterized by high communicative (justification) framing and low normative-legal invocation. The Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned blocs are statistically indistinguishable from each other and together define the normative-legal pole of the Dimension 1 axis in the CA.

This finding requires careful interpretation. The Western bloc's lower normative-legal framing does not indicate a lesser commitment to international law as such. A plausible reading of the data would be that Western states – particularly the United States, which dominates the Western subcorpus – have had greater difficulty grounding contested uses of force in the formal UN Charter framework, where Security Council authorization was either absent or contested, and have therefore been pushed toward justificatory rather than norm-invoking argumentation. Iraq 2003 is the most transparent case: with the UNSC divided and no explicit authorization for the use of force, the US delegation could not ground its legitimation in Chapter VII authorization and instead constructed an extended necessity argument based on Iraqi WMD non-compliance and the residual authority of Resolution 1441. The normative vocabulary was available; its use would have been politically and legally incoherent in that context.

The Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern blocs' preference for normative-legal framing may, conversely, reflect the fact that these states have more consistently faced challenges to their sovereign authority – challenges to which the non-interference norm and formal legal equality provide the most immediately available and normatively legitimate response before a universal audience. The UN Charter's prohibition on interference in internal affairs (Article 2(7)) is particularly salient for states facing human rights allegations or responses to internal conflicts, which are among the most frequent allegation types in the NAM subcorpus.

4.6.1. Summary of Empirical Findings

The four hypotheses receive the following empirical assessments on the basis of the analysis above:

H1 (convergence) is supported. Post-9/11 counter-terrorism framing increased uniformly across all three blocs, with no statistically significant inter-bloc differentiation in either the pre- or post-2001 period. The pattern supports the claim of ideational convergence in the adoption of a new legitimation resource.

H2 (repertoire) is partially supported with qualification. The dominant strategies across the corpus are not purely strategic evasion or denial – strategic action is entirely absent as a dominant mode. Normative-legal framing is substantial (36.1 percent of classified content) and procedural-legal claims are the second most frequent manual strategy (28 segments). However, the single most prevalent type is communicative action – justification through necessity and counter-terrorism arguments – rather than normative-legal action as H2 predicted. The hypothesis requires reformulation: the repertoire is not primarily normative-legal but is genuinely legitimation-oriented, with justificatory reasoning displacing formal norm invocation, particularly in the post-9/11 period.

H3 (temporal shift) is supported. The distribution of Habermas action types shifts significantly across historical periods ($\chi^2(6) = 21.06, p = 0.0018$). The clearest shift is the post-9/11 transition from normative dominance to communicative dominance, driven by the adoption of counter-terrorism framing. The post-2014 period shows partial reversion toward normative invocation.

H4 (geopolitical variation) is supported. Western states show systematically lower normative-legal framing and significantly higher communicative (justification) framing than both Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states. The CA Dimension 1 is interpretable as a justification–norm invocation axis, with the Western bloc at the justification pole and the other two blocs at the normative pole. Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states are not significantly differentiated from each other.

5. Discussion

5.1. Hypothesis Assessment

Four hypotheses were specified in Chapter 2 and subjected to empirical test in Chapter 4. The results are uneven in instructive ways.

H1 (ideational convergence) is supported unambiguously. The post-9/11 adoption of counter-terrorism framing is not a Western or Soviet/Eastern phenomenon – it is a cross-bloc one. ANOVA results for the pre-2001 and post-2001 periods both fail to detect inter-bloc differentiation ($F = 0.39, p = .678$ and $F = 1.29, p = .288$ respectively), while within-bloc t-tests confirm

that all three blocs show a statistically significant increase in counter-terrorism keyword density after September 2001. The implication is that UNSC Resolution 1373 and the normative infrastructure of the “war on terror” created a legitimation resource that was taken up across the international system – not selectively, but uniformly, by states with widely divergent strategic interests and adversarial relationships. Counter-terrorism framing became, in effect, a shared rhetorical commons.

H2 (repertoire) is supported with a significant qualification. The hypothesis predicted that dominant strategies would be normative-legal – Charter invocations, self-defense claims, sovereignty appeals. The data show something more complex. Strategic action is indeed absent as a dominant mode – zero classified segments are coded under denial, counter-accusation, or delegitimation as their primary Habermas type – confirming that states before the General Assembly do not simply refuse to legitimize. But the dominant mode is not normative-legal (36.1 percent) but communicative, specifically justificatory (51.5 percent). Direct invocations of Article 51 are nearly absent from the manual coding ($n = 1$); the more common pattern is the construction of necessity arguments through counter-terrorism framing, with formal legal citation as support rather than as the primary vehicle. H2 requires reformulation: the repertoire is genuinely legitimation-oriented, but the dominant register is argumentative rather than norm-invoking.

H3 (temporal shift) is supported. The chi-square result for Habermas action types across periods – $\chi^2(6) = 21.06$, $p = .0018$, Cramér’s $V = .33$ – is the most statistically robust finding in the analysis. The shift from Cold War normative dominance (63.6 percent normative in the 1946–1989 sample) to post-9/11 communicative dominance (71.0 percent communicative in 2002–2013) represents not a gradual drift but a threshold crossing. The post-2014 partial reversion toward normative framing (normative rising from 16.1 to 25.9 percent) suggests that the sovereignty-revisionist rhetoric of the fragmentation period partially re-activated the legal argumentation register that the War on Terror years had displaced.

H4 (geopolitical variation) is supported. Fisher’s exact tests establish significant pairwise differentiation between the Western bloc and both the Soviet/Eastern ($p = .023$) and Non-Aligned ($p = .003$) blocs on normative action, with the Western bloc showing a pronounced deficit. The correspondence analysis positions justification and the Western bloc at the same pole of the primary dimension, which accounts for 82.5 percent of total inertia – a concentration indicating that the geopolitical axis of differentiation in legitimation registers is substantially one-dimensional. Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned blocs are not significantly differentiated from each other on any Habermas type.

5.2. Communicative vs. Strategic Action in Practice

The finding that most directly speaks to the Habermasian theoretical framework – and that the prior case-study literature anticipated but could not establish at scale – is the complete absence of strategic action as a dominant communicative mode across three Cold War blocs, four historical periods, and eight distinct legitimation strategy types. Risse (2000) and Bjola (2005) argued theoretically that multilateral forums impose communicative constraints on state speech acts; the corpus-level evidence here provides systematic empirical confirmation of that proposition beyond the individual episodes they examined.

Habermas (1984) distinguishes communicative action from strategic action on the criterion of orientation: communicative action is oriented toward *Verständigung* – reaching understanding through the exchange of reasons – while strategic action is oriented toward causal success, treating the other as a means rather than an interlocutor. The empirical pattern in the UNGA corpus suggests that the General Assembly forum imposes a structural constraint on strategic action at the textual level: every coded speech act, including those that colloquially might be described as deflection or counter-attack, contains sufficient justificatory or normative content to be classified under communicative or normative action. The forum’s public character, universal membership, and founding normative architecture appear to require – at minimum – the performance of legitimation.

The qualification matters. Risse (2000) and Müller (2004) both observe that the distinction between sincere argumentation and strategic mimicry of argument is empirically difficult to establish from discourse data alone. A state may invoke self-defense language without any genuine orientation toward shared normative evaluation; the verbal form of legitimation does not guarantee its communicative substance. What the data establish is more modest but not trivial: states before the General Assembly cannot afford to *appear* strategically oriented. The institutional setting generates a performative demand for normative justification that shapes the rhetorical surface of diplomatic discourse regardless of underlying intent. This matches the logic of deliberative legitimacy that Bjola (2005) identifies: the construction of normative consensus through public argumentation operates as a constraint on state behavior even when states have no intention of being bound by the consensus they construct.

The bloc-level register differentiation identified under H4 adds a further layer of theoretical complexity. Western states construct necessity arguments; non-Western states invoke legal norms. Both are forms of legitimation, but they make structurally different validity claims (Habermas, 1984): communicative action claims normative rightness through propositional argument about consequences and proportionality, while normative action claims rightness through the assertion of shared binding standards. The Western preference for justificatory framing over formal legal invocation plausibly reflects the

structural position of states whose contested actions have often been undertaken without Security Council authorization – a context in which formal Charter invocations would be legally and politically incoherent. The structural logic is documented in Section 4.6: when the formal Charter framework is unavailable, the substitution is quasi-legal necessity argumentation rather than an abandonment of legitimation. The non-Western preference for normative-legal framing, by contrast, reflects the centrality of Article 2(7) and formal legal equality to states whose primary exposure to international criticism concerns the exercise of domestic sovereign authority rather than external military conduct.

5.3. Theoretical Contributions and Limitations

The analysis makes three contributions to the literature on legitimation discourse in international politics.

First, it provides systematic, corpus-based evidence for patterns that prior IR scholarship has described primarily through case analysis. Bjola (2005), Risse (2000), and Müller (2004) establish the relevance of communicative action to diplomatic practice through close readings of individual episodes – Kosovo, Iraq, the Helsinki process. The present analysis shows, across 33 case-years and 102 coded segments, that communicative action is not only theoretically applicable but empirically prevalent – and more prevalent than normative-legal invocation in the post-Cold War period. The shift to a corpus-level perspective does not replace the qualitative depth of case analysis; it provides the horizontal dimension that case studies structurally cannot.

Second, the register differentiation finding contributes to ongoing debates about what the “rules-based order” means in practice. States that rhetorically champion that order invoke formal legal norms less frequently in cases of contested conduct than their non-Western counterparts – a pattern confirmed at the $p < .01$ level for the Western vs. Non-Aligned comparison. This is not evidence of hypocrisy in any simple sense; it reflects different structural exposures to the Charter architecture. Koskeniemi’s (2005) account of the structure of international legal argument is instructive here: legal argumentation oscillates between descending claims (appeals to objective norms) and ascending claims (appeals to state consent and practice), and states whose contested actions fall outside the formal Charter authorization framework face a structural disincentive against descending invocations of Charter law – because those very norms would render their conduct indefensible. The quasi-legal justificatory register characteristic of Western diplomatic argumentation in the corpus is, in this reading, a structurally conditioned adaptation rather than a strategic preference. The empirical pattern – non-Western states invoking Charter provisions and legal instruments more consistently, while Western argumentation operates through necessity claims and securitization framing – complicates narratives in which Western

states function as primary custodians of the rules-based order, pointing instead toward structural asymmetries that are observable in the discourse independently of any actor's stated normative commitments.

Third, the temporal finding supports the argument that September 2001 functioned as a discursive turning point – not merely a geopolitical one – that reconfigured the normative vocabulary available to all state actors regardless of strategic alignment. Wiener's (2014) theory of contestation provides the theoretical framing: norm-generative events of sufficient salience can reset the available repertoire of legitimation resources across the international system, such that new discursive resources become available to actors whose prior normative positions would not ordinarily support them. The institutionalization of UNSC Resolution 1373's counter-terrorism framework is precisely such an event: it created a legitimation resource adopted rapidly and uniformly across three blocs with widely divergent strategic interests.

Two limitations constrain the scope of these contributions. The keyword-based classification is necessarily reductive: the nine communicative roles are operationalized through lexicons that capture dominant patterns while missing indirect or highly institutionalized formulations, as the elevated Western unclassified rate (11.1 percent) indicates. This is not a methodological failure – it is an analytically informative asymmetry – but it means the classification performs differentially across rhetorical registers and cannot fully capture the hedged, institutionally framed argumentation characteristic of Anglo-American diplomatic prose. The analysis also covers a single venue. Whether the legitimation patterns identified in General Debate speeches characterize diplomatic discourse more broadly – in the Security Council, in bilateral channels, in official state media – remains an open question that the UNGDC corpus, by design, cannot address.

5.4. Directions for Future Research

Three extensions appear most immediately productive. The first is a cross-venue comparison: systematically applying the coding framework to Security Council debates for the same state-years as the present sample would test whether legitimation registers shift when the audience changes from the universal membership of the General Assembly to the restricted great-power veto context of the Council. The expectation is that Security Council rhetoric would show higher normative-legal framing and reduced counter-terrorism argumentation – the Council's institutional architecture incentivizes legal citation more directly than the General Debate format, while the absence of a universal audience reduces the rhetorical payoff of broad-coalition counter-terrorism framing.

The second extension concerns the temporal scope of the corpus itself. Pre-1956 speeches – which fall within the UNGDC’s coverage from Jankin, Baturo, and Dasandi (2025) but are underrepresented in the present sample due to sparser documentation of contested episodes – would allow assessment of whether Cold War normative dominance was present from the founding of the UN system or emerged gradually over the first decade of the organization’s operation. The hypothesis that early General Assembly sessions showed more explicit legal-formalist argumentation, before counter-terrorism framing and quasi-legal necessity arguments became available, is testable with the extended corpus.

The third extension addresses the translation constraint. All non-English speeches in the UNGDC are represented through official UN translations. For the Arabic, Chinese, and Russian subcorpora – which together account for the majority of the Non-Aligned and Soviet/Eastern segments in the present sample – systematic comparison of original-language texts with their English translations would test whether the keyword-based classification performs equivalently across the two versions or whether the translation process consistently flattens strategic distinctions in ways that distort the role assignments. Such a comparison would be particularly important for the assessment of the H4 finding, where bloc-level differences in normative-legal framing are substantial and theoretically consequential.

Conclusion

The question driving this analysis was what legitimation strategies state leaders employ at the UNGA General Debate to justify legally or normatively contested conduct – which appear most frequently, how their distribution has shifted across seven decades of international politics, and whether geopolitical blocs draw on distinguishable repertoires. Examined across 33 case-years and 102 manually coded segments spanning 1946 to 2023, the corpus permits systematic answers to each of these questions.

The analysis of legitimation discourse in UNGA General Debate speeches between 1946 and 2023 yields findings that confirm three of the four hypotheses directly, and require the reformulation of H2 in a way that is itself a substantive conclusion. State leaders facing allegations of legally or normatively contested conduct do not refuse to legitimize: the complete absence of strategic action as a dominant mode – across 33 case-years, four historical periods, and three geopolitical blocs – indicates that the General Assembly forum imposes a structural demand for normative performance that operates independently of the speaker’s strategic intent. Every coded speech in the sample, including those delivered by governments under sustained international criticism, contains sufficient justificatory or normative content to be classified as communicative or normative action. H2, as specified, predicted normative-legal dominance; the data show communicative-justificatory framing in the leading register instead. The

structural claim holds – strategic action is absent as a dominant mode – but the characteristic form legitimization takes in the corpus is argumentative rather than norm-invoking.

Of the strategies identified, counter-terrorism and securitization framing (34.3% of coded segments) and procedural-legal claims (27.5%) together account for nearly two-thirds of the sample. Explicit self-defense invocations under Article 51 of the UN Charter appear in only one coded segment; the characteristic pattern is the construction of necessity arguments through securitization language, with formal legal citation as supporting rather than primary vehicle. The temporal distribution of these strategies is not stable. A statistically significant shift – $\chi^2(6) = 21.06$, $p = .0018$ – marks the transition from Cold War normative dominance, when Charter invocations and sovereignty appeals accounted for 63.6% of classified segments, to post-9/11 communicative dominance, when justificatory framing reached 71.0% of classified content in the 2002–2013 sample. September 2001 functions in this data as a threshold crossing rather than a gradual drift: the counter-terrorism infrastructure that followed created a legitimization resource adopted rapidly across the full spectrum of the UN membership. The Post-2014 period partially reverses this trajectory – normative-legal framing recovers to 25.9% – consistent with the intensification of sovereignty-revisionist argumentation among states operating in an environment of increased normative contestation.

The geopolitical dimension of the analysis produces a more complex picture than either convergence or divergence accounts alone can accommodate. At the level of counter-terrorism rhetoric, convergence is unambiguous: post-2001 adoption of securitization framing is cross-bloc and not significantly differentiated across the three analytical groupings. At the level of legitimization register, however, divergence is equally robust: Western states rely predominantly on communicative justification, while Soviet/Eastern and Non-Aligned states rely more consistently on normative-legal invocations – Charter provisions, treaty authority, the non-interference principle. The Fisher's exact pairwise comparisons confirm the Western bloc's deficit in normative-legal framing at $p = .023$ relative to the Soviet/Eastern grouping and $p = .003$ relative to the Non-Aligned Movement. These two patterns – surface convergence in rhetorical resources, structural divergence in legitimization register – operate at different analytical levels and are not contradictory. They reflect the availability of a shared post-2001 vocabulary alongside the persistence of structurally conditioned differences in how states relate to the Charter architecture.

These findings make three contributions to the IR literature. At the empirical level, the analysis provides systematic, corpus-based evidence for patterns that prior scholarship has identified through case analysis – confirming, across 102 coded segments, that communicative action is empirically prevalent in

UNGA legitimization discourse and more frequent than normative-legal invocation in every post-Cold War period. At the theoretical level, the results extend Bjola's (2005) account of deliberative legitimacy beyond the two episodes – Kosovo and Iraq – on which it was originally grounded, demonstrating that the forum-level constraint it describes holds across three blocs and seven decades. At the interpretive level, the register differentiation finding – Western states employing quasi-legal justificatory framing while non-Western states invoke formal Charter-grounded norms – complicates received narratives of Western states as primary custodians of the 'rules-based order', pointing instead toward structurally conditioned asymmetries – of the kind Koskeniemi (2005) describes in tracing the oscillation between descending and ascending legal argument – that are observable in the discourse independently of any actor's stated normative commitments.

The broader significance of these findings lies in what they reveal about the durability of the UNGA as a legitimization arena. The General Debate remains the single venue at which every UN member state is obligated to appear and address a universal audience – without veto and without the procedural constraints of the Security Council. As the normative architecture of the postwar order has come under sustained pressure since 2014, the question of how states legitimize legally contested conduct before that audience becomes analytically important precisely because the forum continues to function. The evidence presented here suggests that the communicative demand of the General Assembly has not collapsed under normative fragmentation: even in the most recent period of the corpus, states continue to perform legitimization rather than abandon it. Tracking the strategies through which that performance is constructed, and the conditions under which the repertoire shifts, is a precondition for any systematic account of how international norms are contested, sustained, and reconstructed under pressure. For the period 1946–2023, across four historical periods and three geopolitical blocs, this analysis has provided that account – documenting not the collapse of legitimization under normative fragmentation, but its persistence and structural transformation.

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